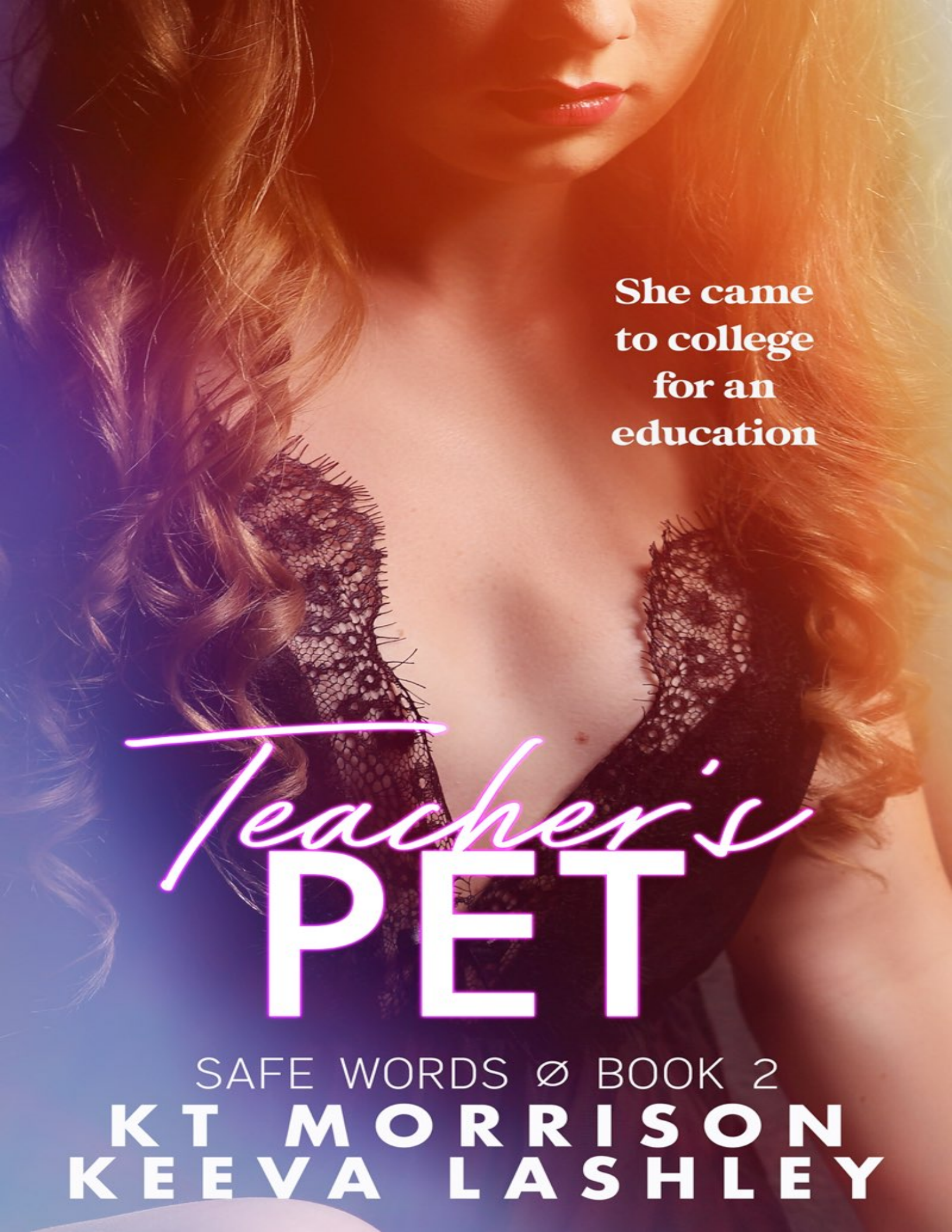




She came
to college
for an
education

Teacher's
PET

SAFE WORDS Ø BOOK 2

KT MORRISON
KEEVA LASHLEY

teacher's pet

Safe Words

Book Two

kt morrison

keeva lashley

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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

This book contains instances of BDSM and spanking and is meant for mature audiences.

TEACHER'S PET

A Safe Words Serial Novella

Book 2

28,00 words

First Edition. February 3, 2020.

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Written by Keeva Lashley

Cover by Keeva Lashley

about the author

KT Morrison writes complicated and kinky love stories.

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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

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GOOD GIRL

Safe Words // Book 1

38,000 words

Second Edition. December 5, 2022.

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Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

foreword

This story of a shy young college woman named Angel Parker will unfold over a handful of serial novellas. Angel will be drawn deeper and deeper into her Master's abyss—what starts as sexual curiosity will blossom into something larger, darker, profounder . . . Angel will find love in the most unexpected circumstance—but can she endure its power?

—KT

1

dawning

Wednesday, November 13

THERE WAS A PICTURE THAT HUNG IN HER LOCKER BACK IN HAGER Hill High. A letter-size sheet of paper printed in faded hues from the family printer and gifted by her mother, stuck center-inside-door at eye-height with a short strip of invisible tape. A motivational quote overtop a beautiful photo. A jagged tree line crossed near-bottom, the foreground a foggy field. The majority of the photo was a dawning sky, the sun winking its first light as it breached the tree line. Written across the sky in fancy fonts, varying in style to emphasize each line, was the quote: “To make your dreams come true, the first step is waking up.”

Was waking up metaphorical? Was there some philosophical revelation implied? Was the author a purveyor of tinfoil hattery?—wake up to chem trails, tower seven, the military industrial complex, reptilians, the illuminati . . .? With her mother it might be hard to tell (from where Mom plucked that quote might be alarming). But the importance of the quote was her mother’s intention. *Get up, Angel, you’ve got work to do!* But Mom wasn’t a disciplinarian, wasn’t the one who’d beaten into her daughter to rise early. Angel just did it. She’d been the first Parker offspring, the first of three daughters. Farm chores were a reality, and they’d become her ritual without parental provocation. Heck, her sisters weren’t early risers. Mom admired her dedication and gave her the quote for her locker not as an instructive but

a reinforcement. *I know you're working hard, honey, and I admire you for it.*

Now here it was just half-past six in the morning and she and her track team were on mile nine around the gravel trail of The Ten Mile Wood, the sun breaching the tree line, giving its first wink to the oncoming day.

Breath coming in even but heavy syncopation, she paced herself behind Sixian Chu, watching her teammate's spandex butt shaking as all the girls hoofed it through the forest. Angel was mid-pack, and somewhere behind her Deanna, the assistant coach, would be trailing, bringing up the rear and analyzing them all. Deanna'd brought her in for a meeting before the morning's run, a 5:30 A.M. face-to-face over Deanna's desk, a moment for them to both acknowledge the slip in Angel's sprint times. Nothing presented as excuse or path forward, merely a laying out of the cards on the table. A baring of the truth, but one that came heavy with obligation. *Your times need to be faster.* Something she knew, and something already weighing on her.

A small portion of her total scholarship was based on an Illinois fund run by Helen Komen, a successful business woman in southern Illinois who ran track at Yale in the 1960s. A five-grand tuition supplement to any young woman pursuing track at college. Even for that scholarship she'd had to write a three-thousand word plea outlining her struggles for the academic while also knee-deep in athletics, and of course the obligatory appendix of any other familial hardships. That was for the smallest of her scholarships. She had the Reinhardt-Klein which required her to maintain a competitive GPA, and the Trailblazer required the same plus figurehead work, being the Trailblazer spokesperson for a year, writing articles for their program and touring high schools near the end of the school year. It wasn't ungratefulness, but tremendous worry came with the responsibility. The shame that would come if her grades slipped, and the scholarship revoked next year. Everyone in Hager Hill saying Angel big-shot, girl who thought

she was worth something, seeing her around town, maybe at the co-op or down at the Walmart, taking a year off from college trying to figure out what she would screw up next.

Without any one of those three scholarships in play, she didn't think she'd be here next year at all. Definitely not without the Reinhardt or the Trailblazer. So while a slip in her sprint times didn't mean she was off the team, it was a skidding in that direction. Enough she could lay in bed at night and look at the ceiling, worrying about it till the insides of her cheeks had been chewed raw. Picturing herself at the kitchen table (her sisters in bed for the night), breaking the news to her parents she wasn't qualified, wasn't good enough, the tidal swell of shame so real she couldn't breathe sometimes under the dorm room bedding.

Now they were coming around the trail, counterclockwise if seen from above, to the eastern most point where they'd begun, the run's end less than a mile away. The Ten Mile Wood was a public owned forest with a managed trail network that wasn't Morrison College's property, but bordered. A patch of forest in the valley of Barnett Creek; her favorite stretch the western most: a flat of fields owned by a dairy farm, and in September there were cows and a single white horse that would sometimes pace the girls while they ran past. Now in November she could only smell the cows, the empty field yellowed, bent over and lonely.

Wednesdays were distance days. Distance then squats.

Wednesdays were also U.S. History, her class taught by Professor Grace Chen. A grown woman who'd touched that slick secret space between her legs.

At 1 P.M. today she'd be before the powerful woman again, and in her heart she couldn't wait. Her brain however secretly concocted excuses to skip. *At Grace's command, you curled over her husband's lap, he spanked you, and she and her husband fingered you and pleased you, made you come so hard you went feral. You'd only just met the man. But what a man.*

Grace is your Professor, are you crazy? Probably best if you drop U. S. History—but what would that do to your scholarship? It's November already. Have you read all the paperwork? . . .

She was going to follow her heart. She would go to class. She would see Grace Chen today. It would be rude not to, the woman and her husband had invited her to go away this weekend to Rhode Island and stay at their home, attend as their guests a gala at the Museum of Fine Arts in Boston. *Oh God, what the hell are you doing, Angel?*

As the Ten Mile Trail, the Woods's ten-mile outer ring, came to an end near the trailhead, the gravel path widened and grew erratic, a lobulated scruff pecked with short young conifers. A black car had nosed from the parking area and partway onto the trail, parked with the engine turned off. Dawn had turned the light from night-blue to cold gray, and she could see the car was a spotless Mercedes sedan with blacked-out windows that gleamed dully in the rising sunlight.

All the girls checked it out as they passed. Or checked themselves out; every surface shone mirror-like. As Angel passed all she could see in the paint and the windows was her own warbled reflection jabbing along, sweaty ponytail bobbing.

As they'd arrived this morning at a quarter-to-six, walking the path from campus to this trailhead, a car had pulled into the parking lot, but kept its distance, headlights on. But now it was almost seven, more cars parked, Morrison residents out for their own run or walking their dogs. Could it be the same car? Something about it bothered her. The blackness, the spotlessness, both reminding her of Grace's Range Rover Mr. Jones had delivered her home in last Friday night. It was the kind of expensive car one would expect someone like Grace Chen to drive. Not just a well-compensated liberal arts college professor—because this Mercedes wasn't like one you were used to seeing. It looked special, like a high-end one, with more swooping shapes, bigger wheels. It also wasn't the first time

she'd seen it. Since the party at Hull House she'd seen it now a half-dozen times, maybe.

As she and the others bounded into the parking lot, all of them heaving, complaining, gasping, she patted backs, pretended to check her watch, eyes over her wrist and watching the weird black car just sitting there. Maybe sitting there since the run began. A chill made her shiver.

Deanna brought up the rear, slowing to a trot and checking her watch. When she stopped, she wove through the panting girls all stooped with hands on knees. She clapped her hands enthusiastically, the claps echoing through the cold woods, saying, "Let's go, ladies, let's hit the weights . . ."

2

homestead

THE TRAILBLAZER SCHOLARSHIP COVERED HER MEAL PLAN. TWENTY-one meals a week, but this morning it was only coffee with cream and extra sugar.

After squats, the team hit the showers at the McKenzie Sports Barn (where the weight room was free so they weren't fighting with the boys at the Bettis Complex). The showers at the Barn were in single-person stalls, but the change room was open. She wore a towel. Baron's red hand marks on her ass had faded to pale pink, but were still visible even fifty hours later. That Monday morning run had been wild. The lycra running pants she wore scratched at the stinging skin. Every stride reminded her of being over his knee. While it was uncomfortable, there was an undeniable *sexual* heaviness under her stomach that she liked.

Wednesday mornings she would call home after training. Forty-six degrees in Vermont now, so she couldn't do it under a tree in the field like she used to, but there was a side entrance to the old Morrison Commons Building that was dead quiet and she'd been calling from there since mid-October. Saturday, she'd called Mom to tell her how it went going out with India. It was a hard phone call, her Mom bubbling over how her daughter'd gone out as friends with a semi-famous person. Also how her quiet and insulated daughter'd done a normal and social thing for once. Something

she figured her Mom wanted vicariously—an abundant and happy college life, one she probably imagined for herself, having married Dad right after high school and getting to work on babies and motherhood and farmhouse living before she was twenty. Angel told her about the Chi party. Mom wanted to know what she wore. She told her. *And what did India wear?* She told her. *That sounds so amazing . . .* Told Mom she went to another party after, Mom asked where, told her it was another house. *A frat house?* She'd said Kind of. It hurt to lie to her.

It wasn't their loving and dedicated daughter in that mansion. Not the early riser, studious bookworm, runner, teacher's pet . . . No. It wasn't her in the mansion that night. That girl wouldn't bend over a man's knee and let the man and his wife look at her vagina, finger it, spank her . . .

"Shoot," she sighed, temples getting tight just thinking about it. *Who was that girl then, Angel?* She sipped sweet creamy coffee, sitting in a quiet stairwell on a landing's top step, her view out at the vacant Planter Field outside Morrison's main campus building. Breath held, she dialed to Face-Time, slowly exhaled while the phone rang. Mom answered on the tail of the first ring like she'd been waiting.

"What's up, Sugar Plum?"

Mom was in the kitchen, camera too close, and in far too good a mood for this early in the morning. It was 8:30 in Vermont, 7:30 back home on the farm, and Mom would be heading out the door in a moment to fire up the school bus, head on her route grabbing the rural kids to take them into town for the start of classes. In the sliver of space the camera afforded beyond Mom's head, she could see their family breakfast nook with half eaten plates, a box of cereal and a carton of Florida OJ. Part of an arm and a whole hand she assumed belonged to her sister, Hannah, probably texting.

"Not much, Mom," she said, then told her how school was going, how the run went this morning; things she always went over on Wednesday morning, the whole while Mom struggling to get ready, putting things back

in the fridge, getting the pan in the sink to be washed later when her bus run was done. The camera would alternate to a jittery image of her face, then spin around showing blurry swipes of the kitchen.

Mom said aside: “Hannah, come say hi to your sister, please.”

Then her sixteen-year-old sister was there looking more adult than the last time she’d seen her. Hair pulled back, her face showed the surprising color of makeup. Hannah waved unenthusiastically, eyes lazy, saying, “Hey.”

Angel said hey, waved back with the energy she wished her sister would show. Asked where Rebecca was, Hannah said she was in bed still. “How’s Calvin doing?” Calvin was the boy she’d been dating since last month, a new kid in town whose parents opened a fast food franchise on the route into Hager Hill.

Hannah shrugged, leaning on the kitchen counter saying “I don’t know. Fine.” An eye roll was held back.

Camera swished around, Mom’s face looming large again, Mom saying, “Someone’s cranky this morning . . .” In the background, Hannah complained. A plate clacked. The back door to the kitchen opened, boots on linoleum. Dad coming in, Hannah barking about the cold he let in.

Dad’s face filling the screen now, “There’s my Sugar Pop, God, I miss you, baby . . .”

Mom clucked her tongue for taking the Lord’s name in vain.

Two minutes talking to Dad with his Browning camo cap pushed up on his hairline, more gray in his mustache. Mom shooed him away, and he went for more coffee. Then it was her and Mom again, Mom getting right to what she didn’t want to talk about.

“So what are the big plans for this coming weekend, college girl?”

“Oh, I’m not sure, Mom.”

“Nothing with India?” Mom showing genuine disappointment she hated to see.

“No, maybe something.”

“You girls going out?”

She cocked her head, a sudden kink pulling. “I don’t know, I just . . . It’s only Wednesday . . .” Disappointment still there in Mom’s sinking expression—wanting it gone, her mind flickered, settled on a mental image of Sixian Chu’s profile picture on the Morrison track team roster. Sixian’s face, similar to Grace, younger, eighteen, not as beautiful, Sixian Chinese like Grace—no, not like Grace, Sixian born and raised in Ogunquit, Maine. But somehow Sixian a more reasonable partner for any weekend getaway than her older professor. “I might . . . I might go *away* this weekend.”

“Oh?” Hopeful now. “Away where? With India?”

“No. Sixian.” There it was. A lie right to your mother’s face.

“Who’s that?”

“A friend from the track team.” Not really. Friendly, yes. Friend? “We might go to her . . .”

A long pause, Mom waiting. “Where?”

More lies. “To her parent’s place.”

“Really?” Mom happy with the answer, but her mother’s disbelief at her daughter emerging from a self-imposed cocoon palpable. It was upsetting to worry someone; it hurt that her mother spent time concerned her daughter wasn’t making the most of her life. “Where do her parents live?”

Geez, like Rhode Island, a house on the ocean . . . How far would she have to dig this grave for herself? “I don’t know, Mom, I don’t . . . It’s not for sure or anything . . .”

“Wow, that’s amazing, Angel, pumpkin—have you met her parents before?”

“No, Mom, no, it’s not . . . Look,”—I’m just a big liar, lying to your honest face—“I probably won’t go. I think it’s far . . .”

“You should go, Angel.” Supportive. “Are other girls from your track team going?”

Her brow dropped; she looked at the blank black face of her Fitbit, pretended to read the time. “Shoot, Mom, I got class, I have to run to the other side of the campus . . .” Only the same time every week you call, same Women in Europe 1350-1700, HIST 332, you have to go to. What’s today’s big rush, Angel? “Okay?” Her voice had become airy and pleading.

Mom’s unsure look loosened her happier features. “Sure, baby, you go on get to class, I got my munchkins to pick up . . .”

3

dress up

THE JEANS WERE SNUGGER THAN WHEN SHE'D ARRIVED ON CAMPUS. A pair of black Levi's she'd had since sixteen—her only jeans not purchased at the co-op—gripped her ass and upper thighs in a new tighter cinch. Dorm food. Maybe the weightlifting program Deanna had them on.

“What are you doing?”

She turned from the dorm room mirror, India spying on her, bemused, one eyebrow raised. “What . . .?”

India said, “I’ve never seen you check your ass out in the mirror before.”

“I’m not,” she said, a little surly. Then: “They’re getting tight.”

“Angel’s growing a booty,” India said, still smirking, standing facing her closet, wearing a spaghetti strap T-shirt, a bundled Morrison sweatshirt in her arms.

“No, I’m not,” she said, brow going lower, looking at her butt over her shoulder again. “Am I?”

“Sure you are,” she said from inside her sweatshirt, tugging it down her body, then pulling free her huge shaggy ponytail and flicking it rearward. “You’re looking hot.”

“Oh, come on,” she said, front facing now and fixing the collar of her shirt where it appeared above her sweater.

India joined her, looking at her face in the mirror from over her shoulder. “Why you getting so dressed up? You’re not going to class?”

“What?—*no*. I’m going.” They both had U.S. History, post 1865, taught by Professor Chen, beginning in about twenty minutes.

India smiled knowingly, chuckled a grunt in her throat.

“Why are you laughing?”

“You’re dressing up for somebody,” India said, admiring *herself* now, turning her face left then right, checking all the angles.

“No, I’m not.”

“Wear your sweats then. Don’t you have practice after class?”

“Yeah, like at four. I’ll come back and change first.”

“That’s cool,” India said, high and breathy, unchallenging. She turned then, flopped on her bed and picked up her phone, thumbing through it. “You want to borrow something of mine?” She kept reading her phone, then couldn’t stop a smirk, looking up to Angel.

Angel bit her inner cheek. “Doesn’t it look good?” she said, looking down at her own outfit.

“I mean just mix it up a little, wear something no one’s seen you in before.”

She regarded her outfit in the mirror again, her posture sagged and defeated now. Black sweater, white collar shirt, blue jeans, and, yeah, sneakers. Sexy.

India read her mind. “Shoes maybe?”

She moaned: “No . . .” Looked down at her grubby sneakers she wore at high school. Over her shoulder at India’s mountain of shoes. “I couldn’t . . .”

“Heels?”

“I’ll just . . . I’ll just wear my dress shoes.” What she wore to the party last week. Pair of black penny loafers that had seen better days. Not something she’d wear to class.

“Try my heels on.” India tucked her phone in her sweatshirt’s pouch and bounced to her pile of footwear, poking through, finding one with a low black heel, searching for the other.

“No, I can’t . . .”

Matching shoe found, India returned and tossed the pair at Angel’s feet. “Just try them on.”

The heels weren’t something she’d wear to class either. But they were better than her loafers. And *miles* better than her sneakers.

“We’re not the same size,” she complained.

“Not far off, I bet,” India said. “Would you just try them?”

She toed away her sneakers, tugged off socks, pushed India’s shoes right side up with her feet, then slipped them on; first the right, balancing, then the left. They were snug, but fit.

India asked, “They tight?”

“A little, but . . .”

“They fit, don’t they?—*and* they look good.” India put a light grip on Angel’s forearm, stepped back to assess the shoes. “You know—I think you should wear a *higher* heel.”

“I don’t know if I could walk in *these* ones . . .”

“Try.” India held her arms till, walked backward till she saw Angel wouldn’t fall then crossed her arms.

The heels weren’t even four inches, but she could already feel a wobble in her gait. She stood by the mirror, analyzed the shoes. Black, patent leather, a flash of the bare top of her foot between denim cuff and the scoop of the shoe’s design where a tidy tuxedo bow tie sat above the toe.

“*Higher* heels,” India said, eyeing her slyly in the mirror, daring her.

“I don’t know if I could *wear* higher. These are beautiful, India, really.”

India presented a pair of stilettos in the reflection. Sexy, black, red soles. Five-, maybe six-inch heel. A longing to wear them seized her stomach; a notion in her mind that she would look sexy in them. It proved

too much. The thought she would strut into class wearing those scared her: Picturing all the classmates turning around in their stadium rows hearing the click-click of those dagger heels, expecting to see someone like India, only to find a girl like Angel. Playing dress up. Everyone laughing at her.

“I really can’t, India, I swear,” she said, India not taking no, showing a slyer face, rocking the shoes back and forth, see-sawing them, tempting Angel. “India, I’ll fall in those. Imagine if I fold my ankle? I’ll get kicked out of school.”

India rolled her eyes but relented, tossing the higher heels back to their pile. “They’re not going to kick you out if you get injured. Get real.”

“Injured running, no. But injured walking around in your high heel shoes . . .?”

“You worry too much,” India said, laughing, then picking at Angel’s sweater to adjust the fit. “So you gonna tell me who?”

“Who what?”

“Who, what, who, huh . . .?” India laughed, meeting Angel’s eyes in the mirror, getting serious. “Who you’re dressing up for.”

She slumped, her tense expression going watery. “Nobody,” she said in a puff of whisper.

“Nobody, huh?” India plucked her shirt’s collar. “You look good for nobody. Mr. Nobody’s going to like what you’re wearing even if you say it’s not for him.”

He’s not going to be there. Today it’s Mr. Nobody’s *she*. “It’s not anybody you know,” she said, another lie in a growing fortress of lies, brick by brick. “It’s not a big deal.”

India’s lips pursed, eyes narrowing, head nodding. “Come here,” she said, guiding Angel to her dresser. Angel watched her roommate knock through her arsenal of high-end makeup then produce a lipstick. She wound the base, corkscrewing upward a blade of glittering orangey-red. Angel

frowned, reared her head back. India persisted, the lipstick pursuing Angel's lips.

India said, "Loosen your lips, don't make them hard like that."

Angel complied, softening her mouth. India drew the lipstick back and forth, her lips tugging side to side. India mimed the act of spreading the lipstick, munching the interior of her own lips. Angel did the same, getting the silk of India's color into all the seams.

"He's going to notice you now," India said.

Angel turned to her reflection in the small mirror over India's dresser, saw her own face livened with a splash of color she would never have selected for herself. Far too fiery. She whispered, "Is this okay?" The way her red lips moved while she talked was electric.

"Tie your hair back," India said. "You're going to class, not out to the club. You're not wearing makeup, see? Just a little color on your lips. You're beautiful, you can't help it. Hair in a tail, it's like you're still casual, you know? Just going to class, who knows what you might do later. You're not trying to be hot, you *are* hot."

"You're crazy."

"Maybe," India laughed, "but you listen to me, you're going to have that windowsill lined up with jewelry boxes, all the boys on campus after you."

Now Angel laughed too. "I don't want that."

"No, that'd be terrible," India said, eyes going narrow and sexy. "Wear one of my coats."

"I have a coat."

India held her tongue, but Angel knew why India'd offered. Angel's coat was blue. She came to Vermont with a light jacket and a ski parka. Both a royal blue. Sporty. But that wasn't the coat she was talking about. "A new one. Black."

"Let's see it."

Now she scratched her head, going to her closet, worried how the story of this new coat would be told. “My aunt sent one to my Mom, my Mom mailed it. My aunt . . . got it from, like, a church drive or something. One of the parishioners . . .” *Just let it go, Angel. Don’t explain it. It’s just a coat. India doesn’t care for its whole history.*

Grace’s coat withdrawn from her closet, she shrugged it on, Grace’s perfume in her nose now, tightening her tummy.

“Shit. That’s a nice coat,” India said, nodding, admiring.

“I love it,” Angel said, adjusting the cuffs, shifting the lapels, buttoning it up—anything to prevent India from checking the label. It was Chanel. She’d looked it up online, or one close to it, saw how much it was. Like, four whole semesters worth of meal plans for a single coat.

India checked her all over, head going up and down with enthusiastic approval. She smiled, said, “Well, whoever’s Mr. Nobody, he ain’t ready for all this . . .”

4

recent history

IN THE CLASS OF FIFTY FILING ALONG THE AUDITORIUM'S SEMI-CIRCLE stadium seating there was only one face Grace wanted to see. A white face. Pretty, rosy-cheeked. Hair a tangle of strawberry blonde; eyes a hopeful blue that clouded sometimes with bedevilment. What troubled the girl was a mystery.

When Angel's face wasn't spotted, and the minutes crept closer to the start of class, Grace finally began to worry. But worry was weakness . . .

They'd scared her off, she surmised. Though they'd done their best to pique the girl's curiosity, Angel'd been since overwhelmed. She was a timid thing. A timid and perfect thing. It would be disappointing if she weren't to show for class, but the game wouldn't be over. There would be other ways to have the virgin at their feet.

Angel Parker was better than she or Baron hoped a girl could ever be, and it concerned her. They wanted a girl like Angel, one that fulfilled their needs, but hadn't calculated who the girl could be, what her personality would be beyond submissiveness. Angel had surprising charm in her diffidence; far more than starry-eyed wonder at what pleasures her Masters wished to exert. More than a young girl who marveled at the physical pleasure; the mere surface. They'd had girls like that before, ones who enjoyed the sensory gifts she and Baron delivered. Angel's eyes calculated

and measured, the sensory just a communication of something deeper. Angel understood. Or, at least, had the propensity for understanding. Angel's reactions betrayed more than a lust or desire for their acts of dominance. Angel sought to comprehend. The girl took to their dominance fast, her submissive nature drawn to their energy like a loose screw to a magnet. And Angel wondered why, wondered what it was within her so compelled to obey . . . The girl was more than a plaything that would respond to their touch, to their implements, to their punishments. Angel was a true submissive. One who they may take farther than any other girl—because she would lead them there, all of them holding hands, but their Angel out front, feeling ahead with an outstretched leg, testing with her toes.

A wavering golden elation worked from below as Grace saw now her treasure, coming in with the one who was her roommate, an extroverted beauty named India. The two of them almost late, entering, pretending to be engaged in talk, like Angel was unperturbed coming to Grace Chen's class after the things they'd done together. It would mean India had been enjoined in some way, Angel recruiting her friend in some theatrics for Grace's benefit, a bit of high school level subterfuge. Angel wanting to act like she was unaffected coming into this classroom was a sure sign she was fully seated in Grace's control, ready to be strapped in. Would Angel have divulged to India anything that had occurred? Grace would bet wholeheartedly she hadn't.

The girl wore her coat. A black wool Chanel, collar turned up, looking delicious in it, like a chrysalis transforming, becoming . . . Snug jeans the girl'd never worn to class, and what was this?—shoes Grace swore were borrowed. Borrowed from her roommate. A black patent heel. And for some reason that small pale smudge of flesh the girl revealed drew a hungry desire from Grace's belly. That half moon of skin between jean cuff and toe scoop deserved to be smacked, a red mark rising.

Most striking was the intense color on Angel's lips, standing out to Grace below at her podium, like a blazing sexual signal. Angel'd applied lipstick. Or her roommate had done it for her. A fiery color; a pulsing, throbbing red. A color that rustled strong urges inside, wanting right now to take Angel somewhere they could be alone, a place no one would hear her cries of pleasure and her wails of pain.

The more desirous the girl appeared, the more she challenged discipline. This was a rousing beginning to Angel's sexual odyssey, one that was already poking at the stone walls of her Mistress's impenetrable fortress.

She smiled now, the act of smiling a pressure release, a lifting of the kettle's lid to allow the steam's escape. If she didn't smile, she may lick her lips, or tilt her head longingly. The students hadn't seen her smile, but she'd prefer it over a display of ardor.

The smile lingered, waiting for Angel to end her charade of equanimity and look her professor's way.

At last she did, letting India get ahead as they filed into their selected row looking to take their seats. Angel looked up and any thin glaze of indifference the student wore as protection evaporated. Their eyes met with electric desire and it took a trembling grip on her own dominant power not to betray her innermost roiling passion. Angel had no such resolve. Right before her eyes, Angel was seized. The student's mouth hung open (those succulent red cadmium lips!), her eyes wide and glassy, posture opening inexorably like flower petals facing the sun. If the girl were undressed, say laying on Grace's bed, she was sure she could encourage her to part her legs and reveal that furry young woman part of her without uttering a word, veritably controlling Angel's mind merely with her eyes.

Grace released her, careening her gaze away, surveying the other students, gathering their attention for the beginning of their lecture. In her periphery, Angel took her seat and prepared for class.

With everyone settled and prepared she began her lecture with no preamble or fanfare, launching right into the story of Theodore Roosevelt's youth, his introduction to the hardship of life through profound asthma, and overcoming sickness through whatever means necessary. A fine and hopeful place to begin what would become the brutality of the Spanish-American War. The whole while she entertained a fancy at the back of her mind; a mental exercise fabricating tortures for feet tops. Perhaps a reed cane across the tendons of Angel's beautiful feet, the girl bound with jute rope while Baron fucked her ass . . .

DESPITE GRACE'S smile upon entering class, Angel worried over her professor's demeanor while lecturing. Or more specifically, the lack of direct attention lavished her way. Doing her best to keep up, take notes, her foremost mind was preoccupied with feelings of dismissal from Professor Chen. But what the heck? The woman had smiled at her, had made eye contact. The woman *never* smiled in class, and yet she'd just done it for you. That was a real connection. What had you expected? . . . The moment before class began, Grace taking a moment to say in front of everyone, Hey, I'm really looking forward to the weekend, Angel . . .?

Beside her, India craned her neck occasionally and Angel knew it was India searching the class for possible love interests of Angel's. Looking for a guy India figured her roommate might have a crush on. The whole while a growing tension twisting, getting tight enough to snap, just waiting for India to put it together, looking down at the lectern and seeing that beautiful, intelligent woman . . . She regretted now saying a thing to India last Sunday morning about Grace and a man she wondered may be their professor's husband. India was smart. The only person Angel'd ever mentioned out of

the blue was Professor Chen and her husband. Maybe India would also recognize Grace's coat . . .

For two hours the lecture continued. Angel admiring Grace's command on her student's attention, her command of the subject matter. Her body, her style of dress. Today, clad in a black suit and a shimmering blouse in the color of satiny steel. Just the points of her shoes poked beyond the hem of her fine wool pants. Would she ever see Grace naked? Hoo, it was a bewildering thought that got her thighs tightening . . .

She studied her own hand in a break from note taking. Opening and closing it. Wondering what it'd looked like on her professor's breast. She'd held Grace's breast, her hand tucked inside that elaborate leather get up Grace'd worn at the party at Hull House. But what would it *look* like, her pale hand on Grace's warm tawny skin? She knew what it felt like to have that silky skin under her palm. And the nub of her nipple, too. Caught herself then for a long transportive moment wondering on the color of Grace's nipple. It would be brown, she imagined. A chocolate sort of color, darker in the seams, brighter and creamier in the highs, perhaps a touch of auburn . . .

Now she huffed a small laugh, getting India looking her way. She shook her head no, indicating to India it was nothing. But now curious India was scanning the crowd again, searching for Angel's secret future boyfriend, when all she'd laughed about was the slick slithering feeling her thoughts on Grace's breasts produced between her legs. Angel Parker was bisexual. Wow. Who knew? Well, she kind of knew. Just never thought it would be a thing. What would Brian think of that? How mad would he be? Maybe he couldn't be mad. She could tell him she wasn't into guys. Yeah, like he wouldn't be mad at that. Just another thing for him to obsess over, want to correct. Another reason for him to attempt control over her life. Wanting to fix her. "Girls? You like *girls*," he'd say, bothered, edged on anger. She'd

say no. Women. I like *women*. What a conversation that would be. Plus a lie. She liked boys. No, *men*. She liked men. She liked Baron Gravesande.

Next thing she knew, class was over and she was looking around bewildered, wondering how much she'd missed. India closed her laptop, tucked it in her bag, and she did the same. Crap, what *had* she missed? Everyone standing, shrugging on jackets, even Grace down at the podium closing up shop. She'd have to get India's notes later.

India said, "See you tonight?"

Angel said she would, throwing her bag over her shoulder, looking around.

India said, "He here?"

She shook her head no. "He's not in this class."

India said, "He between here and practice?" After History with Grace she had an hour before track practice, practice going on from 4 P.M. till 6:30.

"I hope so," she said.

"Knock 'em dead," India said, smiling, squeezing past, heading out the far side of the lecture hall, on her way to meet Jasmine with whom she had Women in Film.

Angel watched her beautiful roommate bouncing between students who wouldn't say boo to her despite her brusqueness. When she glanced down again to the floor of the clamshell lecture hall, Grace was watching. Two more students brushed past her, then there was no one between her and Grace. Grace curled a finger, beckoning Angel.

She nodded, trotted down, heart rate picking up; a combination of worry and attraction, that razor edge in a relationship where the stakes are high. Wanting Grace and Baron so much she feared contemplating too long, knowing the profounder she considered her relationship, the worse it would crash at her feet when its frail virgin armature couldn't support the weight she'd laden it with. (*What if they didn't feel the same as you?*) The obverse

of the desire was the relative youth of her time with them. What they had was fun, but in the grand scheme of things it amounted to a handful of minutes, a weightless amount—open that hand and watch the dandelion fluff of those minutes flutter away in the slightest breeze.

Grace waited at the podium's side with perfect posture, upright, briefcase in one hand. Student chatter sounds diminished as the last of the crowd bunched at the exits, looking to get to their next class or go do something fun.

No smiles now, Grace regarded her seriously. Angel prompted her: “Yes, Professor Chen?”

Grace waited a beat, as if to wait for them to be alone in the lecture hall, both doors finally closing with a muffled double boom. “Angel, you and I need to talk . . .”

5

paperwork

GRACE HAD A CORNER OFFICE IN THE HISTORY DEPARTMENT, FOURTH floor of the Church-Cooper Building. While there were historic buildings on campus, some two-hundred years old, like Rothschild Hall, Church-Cooper was built in the 1980s, a modern steel and concrete monstrosity of conjoining boxes and cantilevered roofs. Grace's office space combatted the straight-edge pragmatic function of Church-Cooper with curved wooden antiques and the rough or irregular edges of nature. Metal and stone softened with additions like potted ferns, flowers in a tiered stand by the window's edge, chrysanthemum and geranium; frailer flowers, like orchids, collected in vases interspersed along the regimented line of books on her shelves; a bowl on a side table held a pyramid of oranges. Coming in to the office, Grace had plucked the one resting at the pyramid's peak and sat at her desk now peeling away its skin in long snaking strips. It was mesmerizing watching her hands work. Grace had elegant hands with long fingers, nails shaded a pearly champagne. A diamond winked on her wedding ring finger. A gold watch hung loose on her wrist. She hadn't said anything, taking her time, peeling long uninterrupted strips of orange, twirling skeins on her spotless desk.

Angel chose a wing chair at the desk's side, rather than one of the two opposite, wanting to be close. Grace didn't object. At Angel's back, the

view looked down over Cornwell Field, the circular track where she would be running sprints and hurdles in less than an hour. Grace could stand at the window and watch if she were so inclined.

Angel said, "What did you want to talk to me about?"

Grace continued peeling the last of the husk, then set the peeled orange on her desk. She opened a drawer, removed a folded towel and dried her hands. From the same drawer she removed now a letter-size manila envelope and set it close to the desk's edge where Angel could reach it.

She crossed one leg over the other, her pointed high heel shoe bobbing, watching Angel through narrowed eyes that winked in the gray light coming from the window wall that made up the south side of her office. She said, "You and I are about to engage in a relationship."

"We are?" She shifted uncomfortably, sensing a difference in the way they related to each other since the party and wondering what changed. Was it something she'd done?

Grace watched her a moment. "We are," she said at last. "If you accompany me to Boston, I would say we are engaged in a relationship of a kind."

"With Baron, too."

"Yes, Baron as well." This made Grace smile. "But this next stage doesn't concern you and Baron, only you and me." Now she leaned forward and unwound the red string that held the envelope's flap closed. She withdrew a single sheet of crisp white paper and lay it over the envelope, pushing them nearer to Angel. "Come closer, Angel," she said.

Angel dragged the chair closer, sat again. Grace withdrew a pen from the inside pocket of her suit jacket and lay it on the paper.

Angel asked what the paper was for and Grace told her. "It's a contract, Angel. An acknowledgement of a relationship between us."

She asked what kind of relationship and Grace said, "A relationship, Angel. Emotional and physical. This sheet of paper acknowledging it and

setting its parameters will protect us both.”

“From what?”

Grace shrugged, smiled, interlaced her fingers.

“Will you tell the school?” Her heart thudded at the thought. Paperwork meant exposure. From admin to other professors, maybe even her parents . .

“No. This is between you and me. I need you to sign it acknowledging that we are engaged with each other. Do you wish special treatment from me?”

“What? No, of course not,” she said, on the verge of offended.

“I won’t give it to you either. You’ll earn every grade the hard way. Through effort. Not in my bed, and not over my lap, and not begging for release.”

The matter-of-fact tone and humorless expression from Grace chilled her. Aroused her too, hearing the words said aloud. In Grace’s bed. Over her lap. Begging for release. Release from what? From restraints? From sexual closure? She could picture herself now looking in Grace’s eyes, Baron looming behind his wife, Grace doing something between Angel’s tied open legs, and Angel was right there, so close to the pleasure she’d felt on Baron’s lap, needing it, needing it, needing it, and Grace was withholding, making her beg for orgasm. Her cheeks flushed, and she chewed her lip. “I don’t want special treatment, Professor Chen.”

“Sign then, if you please. For my records.”

“Yeah,” she said, seeing no harm in signing the document. She fingered it nearer to read. It laid out in contract style that Angel Parker and Grace Chen were in a relationship. It even said sexual. There it was spelled out: S-E-X-U-A-L. Committed to contract, she would be having sex with her professor. She shifted again, feeling warm all over but a chill of fright tickling up her spine. Now she *wanted* to sign her name. Commit to paper that she would engage in striking sexual acts with a powerful woman she

admired. She played with the pen, popped its top. The nib was a fountain style in gleaming gold. The contract stated that the student's school work would be independent of the relationship, that she would receive no special attention, nor would the student request it.

Eyes turned up to Grace's, she said, "I would never have asked anything from you." Not a condemnation nor a complaint. A proud statement.

Grace smiled and nodded. Angel read further. The contract continued, stating Angel Parker would not drop the class. She asked Grace, "Why would I drop out?"

Grace shrugged, said, "To escape."

Angel tried a smile, like showing how impossible she thought that sounded. Grace stayed serious. Eyes lowered to the contract, she fiddled with the pen, drawing an accidental black line across the pad of her index finger.

Grace said, "If you dropped out, you could attribute it to our relationship."

So if things didn't go well, she'd be required to attend class regardless, even if it were painful. To drop out would be blaming the professor. The contract required adult behavior between them all, decisions made with clear eyes and minds. "I understand," she said.

"You are a smart student. You may sign it now."

She nodded, straightened the page, steadied her arm, scrawled her signature on the line provided, the pen drawing a fine but toothy looping version of her name.

Now it was official, committed to contract. Angel Parker would engage in a sexual relationship with Grace Chen. She set down the pen on the document and sat straight in her chair. Grace held the sheet up to examine, tucked it in the envelope, wound the string that closed it again, returned it to the drawer.

“There now,” Grace sighed and smiled. The act of smiling flooded liquid pleasure through Angel, like the formality was over and that stiffness between them that worried her had just taken off its work shoes and put on slippers. She smiled in return, on the verge of giggling.

Grace said, “Are you looking forward to the weekend?”

Angel nodded, then corrected her aloofness, saying, “Yes, I am, thank you.”

“Thank *you*, Angel. It’s not a gala I was looking forward to, nor dreading, but with you there, I am anticipating . . . an adventure.”

“And . . . Baron?”

“My husband is equally inflamed.”

Angel said, “I’m glad.”

“Would you sit closer to me.” A statement, not a request.

Angel scooted the heavy chair so their knees could touch. Grace sat forward, their faces very close now. She caressed the Chanel coat’s lapels, running her thumbs on the wool admiringly.

“Can I return it to you?”

Grace said, “No. I want to see you in it. You look beautiful today.”

“Thank you.”

Grace raised an eyebrow and Angel knew right away what was missing. “Thank you, Mistress.”

Grace’s eyes roamed her face, up higher. “What will we do about your hair?”

She put a hand up protectively, looking to block her professor from seeing her hair. Was it frizzy? Messy? “What’s wrong with it, Mistress?”

“Not what’s wrong with it, Miss Parker, how will we wear it at the night of the gala?”

“Oh. I hadn’t thought of it.”

Grace contemplated. “I’ll make an appointment in Rhode Island. And we’ll have to dress you as well.”

What she would wear to the gala had already worried her. Almost at one point on the verge of calling to cancel. Recently she'd wondered about borrowing something from India. Worried about that, then, thinking how bad she'd feel if she stretched it out. "I don't want that," she said in a timid voice.

"It's not what *you* want, Angel," Grace said, tightening the lapels of the jacket, shaking her lightly, getting her head rocking, both of them smiling. "If I buy you a dress, it's for *my* pleasure. I can't wait to see your beautiful body presented properly."

"Okay," she said in a soft laugh, looking away.

Grace let go the lapels, lounged in her chair a moment, regarded the peeled orange, then sat up again. She pried loose a wedge with her long nails, then leaned toward Angel. "Come to me, please."

Angel leaned closer. Grace said, "Open that pretty mouth." She did.

Now Grace pushed the curved end of the orange wedge past her lips, held it in place. "Now bite," she said. Angel did, incising upper and lower teeth through the orange slice and severing it in two. Juice spilled over her lips, running to her chin. But Grace held her half of the orange slice, still pressed to Angel's lips, the act somehow indicating for Angel not to move, not to try preventing the juice's spill. Their eyes met; Grace had control of her. She set down the bitten wedge, brought her hand back to Angel's mouth. The smell of orange and Grace's bergamot perfume flooded. Grace planted a long elegant thumb on Angel's lower lip, then swiped it side to side. The thumb moved to the top lip, wiping again. It occurred to Angel she was removing the lipstick. Angel pulled her head away, hurt and embarrassed; she'd only wanted to look nice for her Mistress's benefit.

A surprising swell of tears salted her eyes. She looked to Grace saying, "You don't . . . you don't like it?"

Grace chuckled, recognizing Angel's hurt and seeking to soothe it saying, "I like it very much, Angel. Very much indeed." That thumb

swished on her lower lip again, smudging, smearing. “Your beautiful red mouth distracted me from today’s lecture.”

“Sorry,” she whispered, just a puff of air, Grace’s thumb still mushing the softness of her lip.

“I decide what you wear on your lips. These lips are mine.”

“Did I offend you, Mistress?”

“Say it: These lips are mine.” Grace tilted her chin up, eyes peering, thumb lip-caressing.

Angel said, “These lips are yours,” her heart recovering from the momentary hurt, seeing now the happiness in Grace’s eyes at her student’s compliance.

Grace said, “You wear my color.” Her mouth closed on Angel’s and they kissed. A soft passionate connection. Constrained though, the passion beating at the walls of its confinement but never breaking free. “I choose your color,” she said, looking in Angel’s eyes.

“Because it’s the color you’re wearing?” Angel sucked her lips.

Now Grace’s hands smoothed up and down, palms stroking underneath the coat’s lapels. Just above Angel’s breasts. Her nipples had hardened, and she yearned for Grace’s hands to go lower, maybe even slip *inside* the coat .

..

But she didn’t. Instead, Grace took hold of the lapels again, tightening closed the Chanel coat. “Excellent,” she said. “We’re leaving on Friday. Friday afternoon, after class. I’ll send a car for you. How does six o’clock sound?”

That was it? An interior motor had been ignited, quietly purring inside her now. She said, “Uh . . . yeah. Yes. Six o’clock. Where?”

“Outside Rothschild.”

“Outside? Could I maybe get picked up in town?”

“Why are you going to be in town?”

“No reason. It’s just I’m not sure about a car picking me up in front of my dorm.”

“You’re worried about that henhouse.”

Angel chuckled, getting the metaphor, wondering if Grace knew Angel’d grown up with a henhouse of her own. “I don’t know what people would think.”

“You’ll have bags to carry.”

“Just a knapsack.”

Grace’s eyebrows raised; she smirked. “If you insist. I’ll have someone pick you up in town. Where?”

“The diner? You know the one it’s just as you go into town. It’s all Art Deco, looks like it’s from—”

“The 1950s. Branigan’s, Bennigan’s or something.”

“That’s the one.”

“We fly Friday night, I’ll have you home on Sunday.” Grace looked at her expectantly, like their meeting was adjourned.

“So that’s . . . everything?”

“Was there something more you wanted to know? You *do* have to get going. It’s—” Grace checked her watch, it was loose, and she positioned it so she could read it—“3:35 now. Practice is at four; I imagine your coach says—”

“Four o’clock’s late. Quarter to’s on time.”

“You should be going,” Grace said, eyeing her slyly and leaning forward, but making no further move.

“Okay,” Angel said, rubbing her hands on her denim knees, trying to slick away the dampness. “Friday at six, at the diner.”

“You’re going to have a wonderful weekend. I promise.”

“I really can’t wait,” she said.

“You’re frightened though, aren’t you?”

“I’ve never been to a gala before.”

“You’ll be with Baron and me,” she said, pushing her chair back from the desk and rising now, straightening her jacket. Angel rose as well, not knowing the protocol, looking awkward for a moment, thinking she would hug, maybe kiss, what, shake hands? . . .

“Okay,” she said again, awkwardly, adjusted Grace’s Chanel coat, headed to the office door.

Grace’s soft singing voice: “Oh, one more thing . . .”

6

release

ANGEL PAUSED AN ARM'S BREADTH FROM THE OFFICE DOOR AND turned. Grace was coming around her desk, taking her time, approaching her. Face-to-face, Grace began to unbutton the coat she'd given.

Angel said, "Did you want it back?"

"The coat's yours, Angel," she said, unbuttoning then letting it hang fully open. Angel looked down, watched her professor's hands as they gathered at her waist. Her knuckles bumped upward the hem of Angel's sweater, fingers then tucking into the waistband of her jeans. Angel hitched inward a tight breath and held it, sucking her stomach in. Grace undid the top button of the jeans; when Angel looked up, Grace was watching her eyes. Her professor smiled, and she did too.

The zipper was drawn down, the sound loud in the quiet office. On the other side of the door there were voices from farther down the hallway; administration, teachers, maybe students . . .

Angel whispered, "What are you doing?"

Grace pushed wider the flaps of the unzipped jeans; they were tight, and inching them down took effort, making Angel sway, stepping rearward to lean her back against the office door.

Grace looked down, lifted up the sweater, smiled, said, "I'm glad."

Angel had worn Grace's underthings. Her unzipped jeans showed the front panel of the fine embroidered panties that came all the way from England.

Grace stepped closer, and Angel opened her mouth expecting to receive a kiss. But Grace only looked into her eyes, her hand slipping between them, into that tight space between the denim and the front panel of the expensive underwear. Angel gasped, feeling the woman's fingers play over the tulle and satin and embroidered fabric, the double-layered crotch panel. Her sex throbbed beneath the fabric, buzzing against her professor's touch.

Grace's hand slipped higher, nails dragging against the ticklish skin below her navel, then slid underneath the panties, weaving through the tangle of her pubic hair. She gasped again, this time the airy sound threaded with a moan. Grace's fingers went through her folds with ease. She was wet. Eager. Her hips swayed, hungry for touch. Grace made a low sound in her throat, one of appreciation, showing she liked to find her young student so aroused. The middle finger of Grace's hand ran through the center furrow of her sex, curled slightly upward, breaching but not penetrating. "You haven't let any dirty men in here since Friday, have you?"

"No," she moaned, laughing. "No, Mistress."

"No useless frat boys've put their dirty things inside you?" She plunged deeper.

"No way," Angel whispered. "Mm-Mistress . . ."

"So you're still my virgin?"

"Yes-ss . . ."

"I like to hear that," Grace said, teasing pleasure with her fingers.

Her breath came in heavy pants, back against the wall, Grace's light weight leaning against her, hand stroking pleasure between her legs. Grace said, "It's probably near quarter-to, you should probably be leaving."

Angel groaned, made an uncomfortable sound. "Do you love tormenting me?"

“Yes, I do. I really do,” Grace said, smiling wide.

“What time is it?”

“I don’t think you have time, dear.”

Grace’s finger swirled now, outlining the shape of her clitoris over its hood, flicking it back and tapping lightning bolts of pleasure from her pearl to the front of her brain, white flashes of pleasure behind her eyes. She whispered, “Would you make me . . .”

“Make you what?”

“I can’t to go to practice like this,” she groaned, her stomach tightening, thighs trembling, her core desperate to be relieved of this awful sexual tightness.

“I like the idea of you out there this way. If you’d like, I can get you on the arm of the couch, we’ll take off your jeans; I have a few ways to bring you to orgasm . . .”

“Please, Mistress . . .”

Grace scrutinized her, expression showing dismay. “I really don’t think you have the time— I’d like to watch you out there running in this state, anyway. Maybe you’ll be faster with your thighs greased.”

Angel laughed unexpectedly, surprised to hear humor from her stringent professor.

Grace’s hand slowly slid out from inside her panties; the absence was huge. With her hand gone, so was the proximity to enormous pleasure. She’d been close, but the professor liked to tease.

Now Grace brought her hand up, fingertips touching Angel’s lower lip. She could smell her own slickness, smell the musk of her arousal. “Don’t,” she said, grimacing.

“Hold your head still,” Grace said patiently, hand paused, fingers elegantly poised. Angel stilled. Grace ran the pad of her middle finger back and forth over Angel’s lower lip, then the upper, smiling, cocking her head from side to side reminding her of Ronnie Mitchell in Hager Hill

Elementary who liked to torture frogs. “That’s the wet I like on your lips. That’s what I want you to wear. I like them when they shine with your sex.”

With an effort not to lick the maddening wet off her lips, Angel said in a pleading whisper: “What time is it?”

Grace checked her watch. “3:37.”

“Please . . .” she said again, wanting—*needing*—release.

Grace’s hands touched Angel’s naked hipbones. Angel held her breath again. Grace pushed down the tight denim a little further, stroking the backs of her knuckles against the flat of Angel’s stomach above the waistband of the expensive underwear. Grace said, “Push them down; step out of them.”

With her eyes on her professor’s, Angel pushed down the jeans to her knees, leaned her butt against the door so she could pry her legs out of them, having to stomp on the hems to tug them free.

“Sit on the arm of the couch,” Grace said when Angel was bottomless, walking to her desk.

Angel did what she was told, crossing the square carpet in the center of the office and sitting on the arm of the studded leather couch. She wore just her panties, the shirt and sweater.

Grace opened a drawer in her desk, closed it again, coming now with a phallic object in chrome. November light gleamed along its metallic edges as Grace came closer, hefting what must be a dildo.

Grace looked to Angel’s crotch, and with her knee nudged Angel’s legs wider, her butt cheeks squashed on the couch’s arm, the front V of the panties protruding, the soft hump of her desperate sex beneath.

A button was clicked on the bottom of the chrome dildo and it hummed into quiet life. Angel chewed the inside of her cheek. Never used a vibrator before, and now her professor was going to show her how. She came a long way from home for such a dirty education.

Grace touched the dildo’s nose above the waistline of the panties, and the buzzing hum throbbed through her body into her stomach, so close to

that part of her hungry with need. With the end of the vibrator, Grace pulled forward the panties and looked inside. Angel chewed her cheek again, worried. “Should I . . . shave?”

Grace shook her head no, and made a shushing gesture with an index finger to her lips.

“I’ll do whatever you want.”

“I know you will,” Grace said, stood upright and shut off the vibrator.

The sudden silence dropped the weight of disappointment on her. “Don’t stop,” she said.

Grace smiled.

“Did I do something wrong?—I can be quiet . . .”

Grace checked her watch. “3:42, Angel. 3:45 is late. You’ve got three minutes to get to the Sports Barn.”

“You’re stopping?”

“It’s just not enough time, dear. And I’d never tell you to skip practice.”

“I *can*’t miss it.”

“You’re going to have to figure out how to run with that woman’s ache,” she said, teasingly prodding the vibrator’s tip into Angel’s stomach.

“You’re really stopping? . . .”

“3:43 now, Angel. Time only moves forward.”

“You’re cruel.”

“You’re going to learn to love it,” Grace said, revealing a hidden flash of smile as she turned her back, walked to her desk and put away the chrome dildo.

Angel watched, hoping . . . “Shoot,” she said, knowing now it *was* over.

There was a throb below her navel, a hard knot of desire. Release so close she could touch it, but there wasn’t any time. Grace was right.

She trotted back over the carpet on tiptoes, turned her jeans right side out again and shoved her feet through them, hopping for balance. Grace returned, a leather book held against her chest, pressing it toward Angel and

guiding her back to lean on the door, the book squashing her breasts under the coat. Her hands fiddled with the zip of her pants, trying to close them. She still had to grab her track things from the dorm room.

Grace said, “Hold the book,” and waited till she’d folded her arms around it.

Now Grace said, “When you show me flesh, I punish it.”

“What . . .?”

Grace stepped on the top of her foot. Light, not provoking pain, just persistent pressure. The pressure grew more intense as Grace put her weight on her foot and twisted. Her beautiful professor ground the sole of her shoe in crescents, grit scratching the surface of her skin.

“Ow-ww . . .”

The whisper of her pain made Grace smile and her eyes narrowed. She said, “You show me what you want punished in class. Put red on your lips again and I’ll smear them. Show me the tops of your feet and I’ll stomp on them . . .” She twisted her foot harder, not like she tried to hurt her, just letting her know the feel of her expensive shoe. “The tops of your feet and those lips were all I could think about today—when I should’ve been thinking about President Roosevelt.”

“You distracted me, too.”

“Tut-tut. Don’t make a game of it,” Grace said, removing the sole of her shoe from Angel’s foot and kissing her.

From inside her jacket now, Grace withdrew the fountain pen with which Angel’d signed the contract, and presented it to her. “Take the pen. Take the book.”

“Yes, Mistress . . .”

“The book is a place where you will describe your fantasies. A diary of sexual desires, if you will. And it’s locked.”

She now presented a small key. “This one is yours. I have the other.” Grace slipped the key into the coat’s pocket, her face coming so close it

took everything Angel had not to crane forward and kiss the woman. She closed her eyes and wished . . .

Instead of a kiss, Grace wiped at Angel's mouth. Eyes fluttered open, she discovered Grace wiping at her with a tissue, cleaning the smeared lipstick.

"You can't go out like that," she murmured. "Such a mess." Satisfied with her cleaning, she tucked the tissue away and smiled at Angel—touched her then very gently, cupping a palm between Angel's legs, graceful hand laying in her denim apex. Grace said, "I'd hate to see what it's like down here."

Angel sighed and chuckled breathily. "It's terrible . . ."

The hand patted her pussy through her pants three times, each one lighting up a white sheet of need behind Angel's eyes.

Her Mistress said, "Now get to practice."

7

practice

FROM THE TERRACE BALCONY, THE VIEW RAN ALONG THE RIVER OF under-lit Renaissance facades lining the Schuberting, the Wiener Stadtpark a black scraggly tree-patch beyond. An event at the Kursalon tonight had the Stadtpark's old Vienna pavilion strung with twinkling white lights; a wedding perhaps, a ghostly strain of string instruments playing Ave Verum Corpus carried to his penthouse balcony on the brittle November night air.

He was in Austria as a favor to his cousin, overseeing the finalizing of a Sankt Pölten organic fertilizer concern that showed incredible promise. Paperwork and negotiations for three days straight. Meals and meetings and consultations with the team he'd brought; four lawyers and two advisors from Oxbow. But he'd be home soon.

On cue: his phone buzzed against his chest.

He withdrew it from the inside pocket of his overcoat, *hoping* . . . relieved to see the name of the caller: Grace.

He answered. "I was thinking of you," he said, smiling against the wintry breeze picking up along the avenue and prickling at his cheeks.

Grace's welcome voice in his ear, all the way from Vermont: "Good afternoon, my love."

"*Evening*, love," he laughed.

"I'm distracted," she said.

“I want to hear about it.”

She chuckled, said, “How’s Austria?”

“Frigid.”

Grace asked him: “Where are you?”

He hummed, remembering many fond nights here with Grace. “Our suite at the Imperial. I’m on the balcony. Long day—I just got in. Meetings with Remy and all the guys kept me till nine. I popped in at the bar before I came up. I’m still in my overcoat.”

“Get inside, Baron.”

“You should see the view,” he said. “I think someone’s getting married at the Kursalon.”

“This late?”

“It’s all lit up.” He inhaled cold air, exhaled, shrugged his shoulders and wound his head on his neck. “I’m going inside before I freeze.”

The balcony doors were an arched French set leading to a dome-ceiling sitting room in the Imperial style: pastel yellow, gold trim, gilded and carved chairs and couches, cabinets on the far wall, towering draperies. He closed the door behind him, shutting off the cold and the sound of night traffic on the Kärntner Ring, stomping his feet to beat out the chill, flapping the halves of his cashmere overcoat.

He said, “Are you going to describe your distraction. I can’t wait to hear . . .”

“I’m watching her now,” Grace said.

“You are? Where are you?”

“In my office. She’s running on the field. I can see her from my window.”

He doffed his overcoat, lay it on the arm of a high-back chair. “Describe her.”

“Baron, she’s perfect.”

“Her skin?”

“Pale. Blushed like strawberries. She’s wearing running tights—”

“Short?”

“Yes. A fist’s breadth below her ass.”

“Describe it please.”

Grace laughed. “Round. Taut. You saw it bent over your knee. Now imagine it clad in black spandex and hurtling on strong legs down a clay track. Jumping hurdles too. Can you imagine what I’m seeing? . . . A nineteen-year-old virgin ass.”

“I can’t believe she came to us,” he said, sitting in the chair, staring across the circular room, through the archway that led to the bedroom.

“Believe it. And prepare yourself. She’s even more than we could have hoped for.”

“Stop teasing me.”

“I’m not kidding. She’s perfection, Baron. Our Angel *wants* to learn. *Wants* to be our student.”

“Not for money.”

“No. She wants discipline. She wants domination. Sexual domination. She’s for real.”

He drew in a deep contemplative breath while he undid his tie, tossing it aside to the small sofa. “We’re going to teach her so much.”

“I know she’ll be a wonderful student. I can feel it.”

“I miss you.”

“A few more days. Then we’ll play.”

Another long and breathy exhale, slumping down in the cup of the carved chair, stretching out his long legs. Above him, suspended from the dome’s top, was a curled-arm chandelier in gold, dripping in crystal pendants. Last time he’d been here with Grace, they’d made love on the floor and afterward lay naked together surmising the strength of the chandelier’s support—would it also hold a young woman suspended with

chains? They'd calculated it would with ropes, and assured each other someday they'd find out, laughing and touching . . .

He unzipped his fly, drew out his manhood, half hard and heavy, laying on his thigh. He said to his wife: "My dick is out."

She laughed softly. "I wish I was there."

"I love you more than anything."

She was silent a while, the microphone of her phone rubbing on fabric. At last, she said, "I've got my hand in my pants."

He unbuttoned his shirt and opened it, baring his torso. "You can still see her?"

"She's with her friends. Standing with them. The coach is talking. Her legs . . . Baron, she's *so* perfect."

His wife pleased herself, he could tell by the breath in her voice.

He stroked hard life into his cock, said, "Tell me what you'll do to her . . ."

And Grace told him, talking low into her phone. His wife standing in her college office, her hand in her pants. The way she could stand and masturbate was a testament to her discipline. Grace's eyes would be cast down from the window and watching their subject. The subject a ripe and ready-for-picking youthful perfection. Supple, eager, *virgin* . . . but her sexuality like a Gordian knot. With patience, attention, and discipline, they would have her unwound, laying on their bed with her legs widened, her little strawberry slit open and hungry, shining with excitement, the pinky lips engorged, her soft mouth begging someone to fuck her tight hole . . . It'd been a long and tense few days and it was incredible to hear his love's voice whisper in his ear terrible and dirty things, both of them separated by thousands of miles but connected by unbreakable heartstrings. Grace's vivid descriptions brought him to the edge, and they came together, grunting and gasping into their phones.

They were silent but together for a minute, listening to each other breathe. He gathered tissues from a delicate clawfoot dispenser on the side table and cleaned his chest and stomach, then zipped closed his pants.

Grace said, "I love you, too. More than anything."

"I'll be home soon."

Grace sighed happily. Then: "Oh, she's running hurdles again. Her stride, oh, Baron . . . I ground the sole of my Louboutin on her bare foot. I know she feels it . . ."

No idea what she was talking about, but it was sly whatever his wife was up to and it made him laugh. But he said, "Don't get attached, Grace."

She said, "I'm not. But she's special."

"Don't get attached."

She sighed, and he imagined her soft breath exhaling on his neck, wishing he was home with her now.

They had to be careful. They *would* be careful.

He said, "I want her virginity."

Grace said, "I'm going to get it for you . . ."

EVERY RIGHT FOOT strike had been like a tap on her clitoris. Spikes meet clay; track shoe compresses; pressure is applied on that patch of upper skin over her tendons where Grace had ground the grit with her sexy and expensive shoes; a tight line bolts up the inside of her thigh; her ass flexes . . . her pelvic floor yanks inward . . .

All through practice her clitoris had been engorged, keeping her on a menacing knife edge of orgasm off and on for almost two hours. It was hard to bear, and at the start of practice she'd dreamed of running off when it was six o'clock, skipping the shower, getting into the solo dorm room at Rothschild and masturbating. A prick to burst this over-inflated balloon of

sexual tension. Mid-way through the practice something occurred to her: Mistress wouldn't approve of masturbating. She'd pondered *Why not?* But that was rationalization. Mistress had spoken of control, and discipline, and *owning* her student sexually. That ownership would be paramount, surpassing even self-realized sexual pleasure. Wouldn't it? Three quarters of the way through practice she'd convinced herself of that truth and to deny it was merely a petulant circumventing to get her own way. Child-like. The logic of a child. *Well, Mistress didn't say so . . .*

Sounding like one of her own sisters.

This was the sexual world of adults she was in now, and she would impress her Mistress with maturity.

That meant she wouldn't masturbate no matter how much she wanted. Geez, come on, *Want?* . . . At this point she practically *needed* it. Mistress had brought her cruelly to the river of an orgasm but disallowed her drinking . . .

So now she was in the McKenzie Barn—thirsty, *parched*—closed in a shower stall in the girls' locker room, water running down her body . . . and the tickle of the water's flow between her legs had her stomach heaving in and out, her sex quivering with desperate need. She had to wash there, but how? . . . What a predicament.

Water splashed on her crown the way she stood hunched, feet apart, hands on knees, staring at the tile floor, water eddying around the uneven corroded drain cap. Water slipped down the inside of her thighs, and the more she pushed away thoughts of orgasmic gratification, the greater the throbs of emanating sexual impulse wavered from her core, spreading out in expanding pleasure rings from between her legs like a radar screen.

The stalls were divided but the metal walls didn't touch the floor. And on either side of her, she saw feet. Girl feet, bare, pivoting, flexing, toe-curling, water splashing in thin dancing sheets. Sixian practically pirouetting on her right.

The water coursing the tiles would have run down her teammate's naked bodies, and Lordy, what would that look like, all those hard lean athlete girls with wet-shining skin, like shimmering naked sex fish, and, wait—*oh, don't go there*—what would *Grace* look like? . . . Naked in a shower, her woman's body, that long black hair heavy with shower water, no, *rain* water, she and Grace were naked in the rain, Baron, too, she could picture it, all of them together . . .

“Oh, come on, stop,” she hissed, beating her fists above her knees, trying to chase away these images that made it impossible to hold back this typhoon tidal wave of lust coming to her shore.

How hard was it not to come? Everything she read was how it was hard sometimes for a woman. And it had been, she supposed. But Grace and Baron had turned a key in her starter and got her sex motor purring. Now here she was in a shower, neither of them in proximity at all, and she was going to come without being touched. This infernal water touching her skin—seriously, how would she wash between her legs?

She chewed her lower lip, wincing, stomach tucked in, tightened like a cord, her thighs flexing, and she was doing that thing: Kegels, she'd read—thank you, Teen Vogue—and it was supposed to make her interior stronger, but here it was worsening that ache. It got her chuckling under the water's splash, and at last she thought it was all over, and she'd lost the battle. She shivered and the beginnings of a wild racing tremor rattled her.

Oh, no, blast, it was going to happen, she was going to come and she swore she wouldn't . . .

She *wouldn't* disappoint her Mistress.

While her scalp tingled and tightened and her ears began to ring, she dropped down in a squat and clenched her eyes shut, focusing her mind's eye on a psychic blast that would shoo away this wanton sexual knot . . . and just like that, as the petals of her orgasm flower began to unfurl, her focus chased away its nourishing light and slowly, but surely, the throbbing

approach of orgasm began to abate. She exhaled in quick chuffs, a feeling of control coming over her. She chuckled again, then moaned a sound of regret. It would have been so nice to come.

From the stall on her right: “Angel, you okay?”

“Huh?—yeah . . .” Here she was naked in the shower, anyone peeping down below the stall walls like she’d done spying feet would see their teammate squatted on the floor and hugging her knees, quietly moaning . . . “Just a cramp,” she said, then, the absurdity hitting her, she slapped a hand over her mouth before she made an inappropriate giggle. When she thought it was held in check, she added: “I’m okay,” then had to slap that hand over again.

As the other girls began to filter out of the shower room, she was able to compose herself and stand. It took deep breathing and closing her eyes, but she was sure for the moment that awful heavy sexual feeling between her legs had subsided. She could clean. Soap in her folds, her sex overflowing with slipperiness, she managed not to spark anew any compulsion to stroke pleasure across her membranes.

She would tell Mistress of her discipline. And her Master, when she saw him. There was strength in self-control, strength in her sexual subjugation. It made her proud.

One thing she knew was the strength she had up to this point in her life, resisting Brian in Hager Hill, had its rewards. Her virginity was intact. It was a thing of value. But she didn’t want to be a virgin anymore. She knew who she wanted to take it from her . . .

She would write it down in Grace’s leather-bound book.

8

estate

Friday, November 15

IT WASN'T MR. JONES WHO PICKED HER UP OUTSIDE THE DINER. IT WAS another man. One she recognized, though it took a moment to place from where.

She'd been sitting at the diner's counter, the juke playing Cherry Pink And Apple Blossom White, a brassy mambo song her Mom used to play around the house when she was super little. She didn't know the song was that old. Her stomach was all in squirming knots, feet on the stool's chrome rail, heels bouncing, poking through her chocolate shake and absently staring at a painting of some Marilyn Monroe type pinup woman, bending over but peeking behind her, black lines up the backs of her stockings. She had a hand poised over her open mouth, bright red lipstick, like she was saying, *Oops, you caught me . . .*

The Mercedes pulled up, her spoon clanked on the plate seeing the mystery car. She left her milkshake unfinished, slinging her stuffed school knapsack over her shoulder and trotting to the sidewalk. The black car that had slipped up out front of the diner and parked street-side was definitely *that* Mercedes. Not a regular Mercedes you were used to seeing, but some special one. All swooping angles, big wheels. The one she'd seen multiple times in the last week. The one she thought had been following her. At least she had confirmation now. It *wasn't* her imagination.

The door opened, and this brute with a dense black beard gets out. He had an air about him that was tough to pinpoint but she got it in a few moments. Military. Back home in Hager Hill there were a lot of guys coming back from tours of duty, a lot of them having this same look. The guy was dressed in black jeans with a black zip up jacket. Sunglasses. Doing this thing, looking up and down the street as if he was Secret Service and she was the president. It made her nervous. What, was she in danger? *No*. Good thing she said to meet at the diner, because if this fancy Mercedes had pulled up out front of Rothschild, then this bodyguard-looking guy comes out, checking out all the spectating students for signs of threat, what would people think? Sugar daddy, probably. The ones that didn't know her might think her father was some wealthy industrialist. Start asking around. Find out: Nope. Farmers, her parents, pretty much living harvest to harvest.

The man offered to take her bag, but she'd kept a tight grip on it. She said, "I got my things in here."

He smirked, his beard doing this weird jumpy thing to one side of his face. "Luggage goes in the back, Miss Parker," he'd said and held the door for her. She passed him her knapsack, then got in the back thinking the intimidating man was familiar.

She got it: The foyer of Hull House. The one who'd taken the other girls' coats to check them when they first arrived. He was security at the entrance.

Now she was in the back of the fancy Mercedes heading south out of the town of Morrison. In her ears, Grace's words were spoken in another woman's voice. Grace Chen's Pulitzer runner-up, "The Yellow Peril," in audiobook format. The black-bearded driver was less chatty and more closed off than even Mr. Jones was. Mr. Jones had a measure of charm, this one was all business. At least, she figured, if they ran into trouble on the old mountain trail heading up into the Green Mountains, this guy could protect her from just about anything.

They drove south till they passed through Manchester Village, thereafter turning right, ten more minutes of country woods and he was slowing again. She shut off the audiobook and put her headphones in her pocket. Scooted forward to watch out the windshield.

Through a gap between heavy woods on the left, she could see now an entryway. A small white clapboard gatehouse stood watch, an iron gate left open. Amber bulb lanterns buzzed in the early nighttime, mounted on either side of the guardhouse door. The Mercedes nosed down a gravel path that led through a long tunnel of leafless November trees.

After about half a mile they crossed a squat iron bridge over a creek, the creek flowing to a concrete dam where the river water spilled over. More twists and turns, coming then into a clearing, and ahead of her lay a conglomeration of historic looking buildings. The main house a colonial place, two stories up front, Waller Green, mansard roof. Behind it were additions built on in similar looking boxes. There was a carriage house, a bend in the river here created what looked like a pond with a small dock that led out to the water. On the right, a field with three horses and a man with one horse led by halter.

“Are those her horses?”

The driver said they were, slowing down, bringing the Mercedes to a stop in front of the wide steps that led to the main house’s doorway. Chewing her cheek nervously she watched up at the old house. When the man saw she put her hand on the door lever, he said, “You’re staying in the vehicle.”

When she looked up again, she saw her professor now, emerging from her estate house doors looking elegant in a pant suit and long cashmere coat.

THE DRIVER HELD the door for Grace, and she slipped in the back seat of the Mercedes with Angel, bringing jasmine redolence. The door slammed and as the driver came around the back of the car, Grace showed Angel a smile. Angel breathed her professor in.

It was funny how a person could display so much presence. Grace was a woman unlike any other woman Angel knew, but she couldn't put her finger on what separated Grace from anyone else. Beautiful, yes. Distinguished. All her movements were careful, deliberate, and showed her namesake: grace. Could you learn to carry yourself that way? Was learning enough, or did Grace have something intangible and unattainable? If you could believe in magic, she imagined this would be it on display, because in Grace's presence, Angel felt affected. Even now, with her professor's eyes on her, her heart rate had picked up, and she felt twitchy and quirky, ready to say something young and dumb and awkward.

Finger by finger, Grace plucked off her supple leather gloves, enjoying the way her student's eyes watched—her enjoyment apparent in her narrowing eyes, and a soft chuckle to her breathing. "I am so glad to see you," she said.

"Me too. I mean glad to see *you*. Not me."

Grace smiled still, eyes going narrower, eyes just black brush strokes. "Don't be so nervous, Angel," she said, leaned close, their shoulders touching, then faces drawing nearer. Angel closed her eyes, and Grace's soft, warm feminine hand rested on her cheek. They kissed. Soft, sensual, slow; lingering.

She lost herself in the moment, and when their mouths parted and Grace returned to her side of the Mercedes' back seat, they were already out of the estate and on the main road. Their kiss had lasted the length of the whole winding driveway, and she hadn't got a chance to ask Grace if the horses she saw belonged to her.

She twisted in her seat, looking behind them as the car got up to speed on the country road, heading north still, away from Manchester Village. She said, "We're heading north?"

"We are," Grace said.

"We're not going to Albany?"

Grace's brow furrowed. "What's in Albany, Angel?"

"The airport." *Were they driving all the way to Rhode Island?*

"Oh," Grace laughed. Then: "No, we're not going to Albany."

Now she gathered her hands in her lap. "Baron's already there?"

"Baron's still in Vienna."

"Oh, okay," she said with obvious disappointment.

Grace turned her way. "You'll see him. He returns tomorrow. I'm afraid it's just us two girls tonight. I hope that's all right with you."

Angel made sure Grace saw her smile. "It is. That makes me happy."

"We'll have fun. Now . . ." Grace raised her chin, looking down her nose at Angel. "Will you show me your book?"

"It's in my bag," she said, thumbing over her shoulder to indicate the trunk. "The driver put my stuff back there."

Grace nodded, accepting the answer.

Angel said, "He's . . ." Then quieter: "I saw him at the party. The party at Hull House."

"He was there," Grace said.

She whispered, "He works for you?"

"He does. He's worked for me for a while."

"Was that . . . the party at Hull House: was that *your* party?"

Grace regarded her patiently. "It was, Angel."

"Is that . . . *your* house?"

"Hull? It *was* mine. When I came to Vermont I thought I might live there. But it was too big. Baron still owns it, in some way, I'm sure. I like better where I am now."

“Were those your horses I saw in the fields?”

Grace nodded.

“What does Baron do?”

“Manages a fund. Manages his family’s estate.”

The answers were getting beyond her, and she felt nosy, so she stopped while she was ahead. One more question: “That woman, that redheaded woman who told me her name was Kelly . . .?”

“Yes?”

“She’s okay?”

Grace snuffled laughter through her nose, shook her head gently. “Angel, you are a treasure. I’m very glad our paths crossed.”

“What do you mean?”

“You have such a good heart. Yes, Kelly is fine. Kelly is . . . Well, Kelly’s not her name. She’s . . . an executive, has her privacy. But if you’d like, I could give her *your* number, and she could call you if she was comfortable with that.”

“You don’t have to.”

And now, with Kelly on her mind, a non-sequitur, unprovoked, but she was proud and eager to tell her professor. “I didn’t do anything since . . .” And then chickened out.

Grace raised an eyebrow. “Since . . .?”

“Your office.” While she wanted to tell Grace more plainly, she feared whatever was said would be overheard; there was no divider between the front and back seat, and the driver with the big black beard might hear her. She’d hoped Grace would decipher her meaning without needing further illustration.

Grace purred, smiled, said, “Ah, you mean you haven’t masturbated.”

9

inspection

A BLAZE LICKED HER CHEEKS AND SHE TIGHTENED; SHAME WORKED knots into her shoulder muscles, and her eyes darted to the front for a tell that the driver was listening to them. He showed nothing.

There must have been a bloom of red on her cheeks because Grace stroked Angel's face now, making a sympathetic expression. "Poor, Angel," she said, "but look at you," still stroking, "so proud of yourself. That means it was hard, doesn't it?"

More eye-darting, whispering, "Um . . . yeah."

"Aw, you wanted so bad to flick yourself, but you restrained?"

Angel smiled, knowing Grace was enjoying this, enjoying making her student blush. Now she whispered, "I wanted to, really bad."

"I was mean, wasn't I?" Grace still stroked, but now the softness of her knuckle touching lightly along Angel's neck.

"Whatever you want to do . . ."

"That's my Angel," Grace said, and kissed her again. It got her breath coming heavy, and the feel of Grace's skin tickling like silk was going to drive her crazy.

But now Grace said: "I don't know if I approve of this though." Her eyes roamed Angel's body, and she had to assume her professor meant what

she wore. The Chanel coat, a black sweater, black jeans . . . was it inappropriate? Should she have dressed more finely?

Grace said, “What a disappointment,” pursing her lips, showing lamentation, still eyeing what Angel’d worn.

Hurt twisted; she said, “I’m sorry. I . . .”

Grace said, “No flesh for me to punish.”

“Oh,” Angel said, looking aside, softening. “I didn’t . . . I thought we would be traveling.”

“We are, Angel, we are,” Grace said, “I’m teasing.” And now Grace leaned again, two hands coming to Angel’s waist, making her suck her stomach in.

“What are you doing?”

Grace popped the button of Angel’s jeans, face close, looking in her eyes. She gave no answer, only drew down Angel’s zipper. When her fly was open, Grace peeked.

“I did my laundry,” Angel said defensively. She wore the same jeans she wore to class on Wednesday, and, worse, the same underwear Grace had gifted her. But she *had* gone down to the student-run laundry in town and had all her stuff washed and fluffed and folded.

“More disappointment,” Grace sighed.

“They’re your panties I’m wearing,” she said. “And I’m wearing your bra.”

“I’d hoped you’d have nothing under your clothes.”

“But we’re . . . what if I’m at the airport and they want to . . .”

Grace smirked. “What—look in your pants?”

“Maybe.”

Grace chuckled. “You’d be embarrassed if they discovered you wore no underthings?”

“Yeah.”

Grace humphed, curious at Angel's answer, leaned away and undid the belt she wore, alligator with gold hardware, then unbuttoned and unzipped her elegant slacks. She put her hands at her side, legs parted, her posture inviting: Come and check me.

"Whoa," Angel sighed.

GRACE STARED AND WAITED, but Angel was too afraid to put her hand in her professor's pants. Grace didn't press, and Angel's mind reeled, getting mad at herself, yelling: *Do it! She wants you to do it!*

But still too timid.

Grace said, "Remove your jacket."

That was something she could do. She shrugged out of Grace's warm coat she wore, waited for more instruction.

It came: "And your sweater."

So she did, pulling up her sweater, bundling it in her lap before smoothing back her hair.

"Now your shirt."

She hesitated a moment, glancing to the backside of the driver's head, then over to Grace. "Yes, Mistress." The shirt came over her head and she settled back in the seat, the leather cold on her shoulders where Grace's jacket had slipped down.

Grace pulled the sweater, shirt, and the Chanel coat, and pushed them through to the front of the Mercedes, all of the items piling up in the passenger seat as the car swished along the wintry wooded roadway.

She returned to Angel's side and got close. "You *are* exquisite," she said, the gentle point of her finger tracing over the scalloped trim of the bra she wore. Her nipples hardened fast, feeling bitten.

She whispered, "Are we really doing this here?"

"What is it you think we're doing?"

Angel moaned, then chuckled, drew in a deep breath.

“Your pants now,” Grace whispered near her ear, getting her nipples even tighter.

“Okay,” she said, watching the driver again, hiking her butt up off the seat and shoving her tight jeans down to her knees, prying off her loafers. Grace took over, pulling the jeans down her calves and off her feet. When she tossed them in the front this time, she said to the driver, “Skylar, would you turn the heat up, please.”

“Yes, Grace.”

The driver complied, and now warmer air ballooned up from the footwells. She sat beside her professor, under the woman’s scrutiny now, wearing only underwear. Wet warmth pooled at her core, and her nipples ached. Her stomach heaved in and out with her breath.

Grace’s hand caressed her shoulders and arms, sliding behind then and unhooking her bra. Grace kissed the point of her shoulder as she removed the bra, tossing it behind her, the bra draping over the curve of the front seat. Skylar plucked it between two fingers and reunited it with her other clothing separated from her in the front of the Mercedes.

Grace swayed away, eyes glued to Angel’s bared breasts, admiring them, showing Angel admiration in her expression. Grace licked the pad of a thumb, then caressed Angel’s bolt of a nipple. She hissed, writhed; her mouth fell open. It felt so incredible to surrender to the woman.

“Your panties,” was whispered near her ear now, and while Grace continued to tease warm wet circles around her nipple, Angel raised her hips and pushed her panties down to her knees. When Grace removed them, she closed her legs again, knees touching.

Grace’s eyes were on hers, Grace holding the wad of panties at her mouth and nose, a smile peeking. Then the panties were tossed up front and now she was completely naked and unprotected in the car, her things out of

her reach. Breaths came heavy, and her pulse raced waiting to see what Grace would do next.

Grace's clawed hand dragged nails up the top of Angel's bare thigh and she dug her heels in the floor, stomach going to rock, writhing under the incredible pleasure, and, unbidden, her legs parted.

Grace made an appreciative sound, liking that her student had showed her sex without having to negotiate. She cocked her head, peered between Angel's legs and Angel parted them wider, tilting her pelvis so Grace could see what she wanted to look at.

But it was dim and hard to see, Grace moving her head to get the best angle. Out the windows the sun had descended and the sky was lowering to charcoal gray. Cars hissed by in the other direction.

"Touch me," Angel whispered.

10

flux

GRACE'S HAND CURLED ANGEL'S INNER THIGH THEN SLOWLY SWEEPED UP higher to her crotch, the pad of her thumb finally making electric contact with her pubic hair, rustling it, touching then her folded membranes. The cool of Grace's hand—which she knew to be warm—was a testament to the heat of her own sex. And she knew she was wet, could hear the sticky sound as the heel of Grace's thumb caressed her

“Oh, my,” Grace said with surprise, “Perhaps you *should* have masturbated.”

“You could've . . . could've . . .” But left it unsaid, not daring to blame her overflowing wetness on her Mistress's decision not to unleash an orgasm for her before track practice on Wednesday. But she needed it *now*.

“Oh my goodness,” Grace said, tickling at her labia with her fingertips, “Angel, you're spilling over.”

And now Angel was humping against Grace's touch, her own hands coming up to caress her naked breasts, feeling her hard nipples under her clammy palms.

Grace whispered, “What have I done to you?” Still her fingers teased at Angel's pussy.

Angel gasped and squeaked, made uncomfortable sounds of frustration. Grace stopped and Angel sighed disappointment. When she opened her

eyes, Grace was showing her hand to her.

“Look what you’ve done. I’ve never seen a wetter woman.”

“Suh-mm-sorry . . .”

“Oh no, Pet, believe me, I’m well flattered.” Now she came closer, touched those glistening fingers to Angel’s lips, applied the wet to them like lipstick, getting all her surfaces. Then kissed her lovingly.

Grace twisted in the seat, getting sideways, saying aside to the driver, “Skylar—napkins, please.”

Skylar gave a side glance, nodded, then slowed the big Mercedes, pulling off to the grassy shoulder. Cars passed around them. He leaned to the glove box, opened it, rummaged, turned and passed back to Grace a sheaf of folded over paper napkins.

“Thank you,” Grace said, taking them, using one to dry her fingers. Angel’s legs opened and closed, opened and closed, her pelvic floor tightening and weakening, ratcheting herself closer to an orgasm, but wanting so bad for Grace to commit, and deliver one right now.

But Grace—with her mirthful eyes on Angel’s—said to the hulking black-bearded driver: “Do you see how wet my girl is?”

Angel closed her legs and kept them closed. Skylar turned around, and before he could look in the back, Angel’d covered a forearm over her bare breasts.

Grace said, “She’s making a terrible mess back here. Don’t hide it, Angel. Show Skylar.”

Skylar loomed in the space between the two front seats, staring into the back, black eyes on her naked body.

Grace said, “Part your legs, Pet. Show this man how wet I’ve made you.”

Everything said no, but like a beacon light on a foggy sea, she was drawn to submitting to Grace, somehow sought the safety in surrender. She

whimpered, sucked her own lips between her teeth . . . but opened her legs and let Skylar see that intimate space.

Skylar hummed and nodded, then moved away, opening the glove box. When he returned he held a stubby metal tube. A flashlight. He flicked it on, swept the cone of light over Angel's naked thighs. She closed her legs again. Grace touched her knee, massaged it with her thumb, saying, "Open them. We want to see."

"Oh, God," she whined. But complied. She rolled her eyes up to the ceiling of the Mercedes, legs parting, her labia emitting a soft wet smack. She imagined the beam of the light caressing her, lighting up all her hidden shame, could almost imagine the feel of the flashlight's glare touching her sopping sex.

Grace said, "Look at that . . ."

Angel got the courage to regard them; saw the two of them now looking between her legs, Skylar holding the beam steady, point blank focused between her legs. Her own dew had matted her pelt; droplets clung to her wispy pubic hairs—and as bad as she wanted her legs closed right now, she kept them open.

Skylar scoffed, grunted, "Virgins."

Grace chuckled. "You think she's that wet because she's a virgin."

"They're always so horny," he said.

Grace laughed at that, said, "I'd hoped it was me that did it."

"It was you," Angel whispered.

Skylar said to Grace, "This girl's got it bad for you." The beam still shone between her legs.

Grace smiled but shook her head, disbelief in what she was seeing. "I mean, look at this, Angel," she said, leaning close, taking the bundle of napkins and holding them under her pussy. "Lift, please . . ."

Angel obeyed, raised her ass, and Grace tucked the napkins underneath her. "It just keeps coming out of her. She's going to ruin these seats if it gets

between the stitching . . .”

She whispered, “I’m sorry . . .”

“Skylar said it’s because you’re a virgin. Do you just need a good fucking?”

“No . . . I mean, maybe . . .” Now she felt tears beginning to swell, felt hurt and ashamed.

Grace leaned back, arms folded, face beside Skylar who still watched between Angel’s legs. To Skylar, she said, “We could end that now.” Then to her: “If Skylar were to climb in the back here, we could be done with this breach hanging over our heads.” To Skylar: “You’d fuck her, wouldn’t you, Skylar?”

“Only thing stopping me is you, Grace.”

Grace chuckled. “Angel, show him your pussy, please.”

She chewed her lower lip, flexed her ass to turn her pussy up to Skylar’s gaze.

“No, *show* it to him.”

“I am.”

“Open your petals.”

“Oh, God,” she whined again, squirming under the flashlight’s pointed glare, going out of her mind, a dreadful spike of fear and lust shoved into her guts. Hands moving slow, they crossed her legs, worked to her crotch, fingertips tracing familiar territory, finding the full and swollen curls of sex flesh, stroked them, peeled them back, showed Grace and Skylar her insides.

Grace: “She has a pretty one, doesn’t she?”

Skylar: “It’s perfect.”

“And you’d fuck it?”

“Hard. Give me the word.”

Angel complained with squealing sounds in her throat, ready to explode.

Grace chuckled quietly, said, “Eyes on the road, Skylar.”

Skylar laughed, bounced around in his seat, the flashlight strobing through the Mercedes’s interior. He said over his shoulder, “Put that poor thing out of its misery,” then he had the car in gear, indicator on, and looking to merge back into traffic.

Grace melted against her, purring: “Don’t worry, Pet, I’d never let something terrible happen to you. Unless, of course, I wanted it.” Her hand stroked up the inside of her thigh, from knee to hot sopping sex.

“Please . . .”

“What—you want out of your misery? You want me to get you off?”

“Yes, please, Mistress . . .”

“I own it, don’t I? I own this hungry, weeping gash.” Now her fingers teased again.

Angel mewled, pushed her pussy toward the touch of her professor’s hand.

“You own it,” she whispered.

“How much of it?”

“All of it . . . completely . . . please, just . . .” Her hands balled to fists and pressed into the buttery leather seats of the Mercedes.

“It’s mine, Angel. I own it.” Now Grace slapped the inside of Angel’s thigh, making her squawk.

The act tightened her tummy, and she could feel the slinky, greasy feeling—not just between her legs, but inside her . . .

Her stomach fluttered with the the threat of exigent release; like she could feel the shape of the huge orgasm, but not get a grip on it.

The car slowed.

“This pussy is a perpetual victim of poor timing,” Grace said.

Angel sat up, hands clasped over her aching stomach, twisting with raw sexual need. The Mercedes turned off the road and now wound down a sinuous paved path; the path split through low rolling grass, and in the

distance she could make out a conglomerate of long low buildings lit with fluorescent, set in a ocean patch of asphalt with blinking red signal lights. A small plane taxied; further out, one raced away from them in silence, then lifted off to the sky. It was an airport; small, regional, fifteen minutes from Grace's estate and she never even knew it existed. "We're at an airport?"

"We are, Pet."

"Can I have my clothes, please," she said, orgasm squashed in her mind for the moment, sitting up with her breasts under a forearm, a hand covering her vulva.

"Stay seated," Grace said, sitting forward as the Mercedes pulled nearer to a kiosk lit from inside by bright LED, their car's path blocked by a swing-arm barricade in black and yellow. Two men in security gray uniforms moved around inside.

"Please, no, Grace," she said, "please give me my clothes."

"Sit back, Pet," she said, getting close to her. Angel cuddled against her professor, legs clamped together, still covering up. "The windows are tinted."

"They're going to check inside the car."

"Oh, goodness, can you imagine what they'll think?" Grace stroked fingernails along the length of her thigh.

"Grace, please . . ."

"Obey me, Pet." Now she traced hair from Angel's face and studied her profile.

Her breaths chugged short and rapid, her brain sizzling with electric panic.

SKYLAR OPENED his door and exited, approached the men who huddled in conversation in the open doorway of the small guard hut.

"Open your legs," Grace whispered in her ear.

Angel whimpered, kept her legs closed. Grace's fingers tickled between her thighs, worked the tight seam higher, and Angel let her legs part. When Grace cupped a hand over her pussy, she let out a warbled whimper.

"There-there, my little lady, you're safe with me. Do you trust me?"

She nodded, but wasn't sure; her consciousness was blotted by cold clutching fear.

Grace's finger teased her slit, her face worked under Angel's hair and teeth clamped on her earlobe making her gasp. Her stomach loosened and with that, her sex flooded with a new and powerful flux of her juices.

Grace whispered a souging breath of lust feeling the new fluids spilling from her. Now her fingers made loud smacking noises.

Outside, Skylar looked over his shoulder, and the two security men's gazes came through the windshield—*they were looking right at her*. But they were unseeing, smiling again, chatting with Skylar.

A warm release loosened her further. She whispered, "I'm going to come . . ."

Grace said, "No, you're not," and stopped the pleasure of her fingers, taking up the wadded napkins and wiping Angel's pussy like a toddler's mouth after a bowl of ice cream. "What a mess," she said to herself.

Now Skylar was saying something to the guys who gave up a wave, and he nodded to them, returned to the Mercedes—door opening and closing, and if the guys were watching the interior they would get a glimpse of the naked college girl for sure . . . but their heads were turned down to computers. The swing-arm raised, and the Mercedes passed through. Angel looked up at the oblivious guards at work, completely naked and slipping by them.

She turned to Grace, looking up at her beautiful face lit in the passing pale light from the kiosk. "My stomach hurts so bad," she pleaded.

11

boarding pass

THE MERCEDES DROVE A DIAGONAL LINE ACROSS THE TARMAC HEADED for a four-plane hangar, the evening full dark blue now, the mouth of the hangar open and brightly lit.

She asked, “Could I have my things back *now*?”

Grace didn’t answer, eyes ahead to the hangar.

“My phone and my wallet and I.D. and everything . . .”

As the car whisked into the hangar, the cabin flooded with bright light and she whipped arms around herself to cover her nakedness.

The car came to a stop, nosed toward a small jet with turned-up wing tips, the single plane tenant of the big warehouse space. It loomed above them out the windshield, spotless white and gleaming, a low rumbling whine from its engines. The air-stairs had been lowered, showing the dimly lit interior of the plane inside the doorway. Someone was moving around inside. Beyond the plane, visible under the plane’s belly, legs in coveralls walked.

They weren’t alone in the hangar.

Both Skylar and Grace opened their doors and she crushed arms around herself, pulling her tightly closed knees up, and putting her feet on the seat of the Mercedes. “Please, don’t . . .”

Grace turned and stooped, extending a hand for her. "Come with me, please, Pet."

"Grace . . . I'm *naked*."

"Yes, you'll come with me naked."

"I can't, Grace," she said, then quieter, off to the side: "I really hate being naked . . ."

"You've done so well tonight, Pet. Don't stop now." She wagged her hand expectantly.

"Please, Grace, I can't . . ."

The hand wagged again, once only. "*Now*, Angel."

"But I'm cold, it's like forty degrees out there . . ." With the doors open and the car's heater switched off, she really did feel the frigid touch of winter on her naked skin.

"We'll get warm on the plane." The hand wagged one more time, reached nearer. Now Grace said, "You're going to have to trust me, Angel. You trust me, don't you?"

She nodded but was still unsure. This was one of her worst nightmares.

"If you're a good girl, I'll give you what need."

She regarded the hand without the glove; the woman's elegant fingers, the fine jewelry, the perfect manicure . . . and put out her hand.

Grace's warm grip closed it and her professor guided her out to stand at the side of the Mercedes in the V of the open rear door. The nighttime November chill of Vermont tightened her skin even in the hangar. With her knees tightly pressed together, she dipped low, trying to keep out of the line of sight of anybody else in the hangar, arms folded over her breasts. But it wasn't what Grace wanted. She said, "Stand up, please."

"It's cold."

Grace said, "Pet," and touched Angel under the chin to get her to look in her eyes. "I said stand up, please."

Without complaint now, she did, straightening her legs, her bare feet pressed together insoles touching, naked toes scrunched on the cold concrete. The stone leached the warmth from her body through the soles of her feet. “Please, it’s so cold . . .”

“Unfold your arms.”

“Grace . . .”

“Grace?”

She corrected herself: “Mistress . . .”

No acquiescence or further prompt was offered from her professor. Only silence.

Grace was her Mistress and she’d agreed to submit. Body posture eased, Angel looked to the left toward the plane, someone moving from side to side just beyond the elevated entrance; legs still moving on the other side of the plane. Workmen. At least two of them. If they came around what would they think seeing her standing there naked?

With hesitation, she withdrew her hands from her armpits, let her arms unfold and kept them low but bent, hands touching her stomach.

“Hands at your sides.”

She bit off her objection, chewed the inside of her cheek, her eyes scrolling upward to the rafter ceiling and the racks and racks of long fluorescent tube lighting. The jet engines hummed their whine, the men on the other side of the plane clanged and banged. Skylar moved around to the back of the Mercedes and opened the trunk. She obeyed. Let her hands come to her side, her fingertips tickling at the outside of her thighs. Standing there completely naked and straight, like a Marine at attention.

Not enough. Grace said, “Straighter, please. Stand up straighter.”

She did, arching her back.

“Stick those pretty breasts out.”

She did, stuck her chest right out toward her professor, eyes still up. If she were to look down, she knew her nipples would be standing out harder

than she'd ever seen them before. They felt so tight they might snap. She began to shake. From the cold, for sure, but also trepidation and concern. Thinking now of what terrible things Baron had done to that redheaded woman named Kelly. Was that what was in store for her? Would she submit to Grace in front of all these men? And what exactly would Grace do to her? What if Grace was the more frightening one; more frightening than Baron?

"Is this okay, Mistress?"

"Very good," Grace said. "Come walk to the trunk with me."

Grace led the way, and she followed, keeping her posture as erect as she could but walking on the balls of her feet, trying to minimize the contact with the cold stone floor. Her nipples ached harder than ever. She shivered. Watched Grace's elegant strut ahead of her as they rounded the back of the Mercedes. Skylar was there, and she couldn't help folding a forearm over her breasts and touching a hand to her stomach again, the hand drifting lower, fingers over her pubic patch.

Grace glanced sideways and snapped her fingers. "Uncover."

She did, tentatively, uncovering, recovering—then slowly uncovering again. Standing there now, twitching, eyes up to the ceiling so she didn't have to see Skylar looking over at her naked body. He'd already seen it anyway though, hadn't he?

"Am I supposed to get my bags?"

Grace said, "Skylar will get our bags. Just a moment . . ."

Skylar had her knapsack now, zipping it open and rifling through the contents.

"The book," Grace said to him, and Skylar's large hand produced the leather tome where she'd scrawled her most secret confessions. He handed it to Grace, and from her pocket Grace produced the small key that would open its lock.

With the book open, Grace flicked through the pages. Angel'd only scrawled her secrets on the first three, but Grace didn't read them, only glanced over them, an elegant index finger tracing the lines before snapping the book shut and re-locking it. She tucked it under an arm and Skylar tossed the knapsack back into the trunk. But now he withdrew a fluffy lozenge of folded towels, a pair of women's high-heel shoes (very high), and a tub of single-use bleach wipes. He slammed the trunk shut, put the items on its deck and lay out flat one of the fluffy towels.

Grace said to her, "Come here and stand. I want you to face the trunk and put your hands flat on this towel."

She complied, stepping sideways, having to lean forward slightly to rest her hands on the softness of the towel. "Like this?"

"That's perfect," Grace said, leaning over the trunk at her side, the flaps of her cashmere coat touching Angel's naked back. Grace plucked up the high-heeled shoes with two fingers tucked in their heels and let them plop with hollow sounds on the concrete hangar floor. Skylar stooped and set them straight.

Grace said, "Put your feet wide. Straddle the shoes, please."

Angel did, walking her feet outward so that the upright shoes stood between her outstretched feet. Cold washed up the inside of her opened thighs and tightened her hot and wet creases. She inhaled a soft hiss.

Grace touched a hand in the center of her back and she appreciated the warmth. Then Grace stepped back again, saying, "Lift your right foot, please."

Angel lifted the left first, shook her head and scolded herself, embarrassed, put it down then lifted her right foot. Skylar stooped again, gripped her ankle roughly, and began scrubbing the sole of her bare foot with a bleach wipe, even getting between her toes—which, despite his harsh grip, tickled wildly. With the second towel he dried her foot, then guided it to the matching high-heeled shoe.

Grace said, "Put your foot in the shoe."

She did. They repeated the action then for the left foot, bleaching clean, tickling, toweling dry, placing the foot in the shoe. Now she was five inches taller. Unsteady, but feeling a certain increase in the perception of her power. It was unexpected.

Grace said, "Are you able to turn in the shoes?"

"Yes, Mistress," she said toward the back of the Mercedes, kept her hands at her sides then turned in place to face her professor.

Grace smiled, and her heart beat stronger seeing her Mistress's pleasure.

"Such an excellent student. You really are . . ."

"Thank you, Mistress."

"Now we're going to enter the plane. And you're going to learn to walk on heels."

"With nothing on?"

"With nothing on."

She chewed her cheek lining, her face tightening to a scowl. Grace cupped her neck, then the V of her thumb and finger pressed into her cheeks. She said, "You have to stop those nervous tics. Don't chew your cheek."

"Sorry," she said.

"Now walk ahead, please. I want to see the way you move in your heels. It's very important you take this seriously. One of the most important things you can do is learn how to walk and carry yourself. Do you understand?"

"I understand," she said, pulse and heart rate through the roof, walking across the hangar in high heels with nothing on. Skylar watching. Into the plane—and who was in there to see her naked like this? What if those workmen came around? . . .

It took a moment of preparation (that seemed to drag on forever), but then she was putting out her right leg, walking practically on her toes, unsteady at first, but then gathering confidence. No one was there to see

her, and she walked toward the air-stairs, trying to put out of her mind that her ass was bare right now and that Skylar and Grace were probably watching it.

In ten steps she assumed what she would consider a sexy but controlled walk. On the points of her toes, graceful, swinging her hips but not too far. Not pendulous. Once again: controlled. Not a floozy, as her mother would say, but a woman with grace and power. She walked naked, breasts bouncing lightly, nipples hard and aching, her vision hyper-focused in central dots on those air-stairs, the periphery of her vision foggy and blurred. Her vision shook with her heartbeat and the click of the heels that echoed through the rafters.

12

g700

UP THE STAIRS NAKED, GRACE FOLLOWED CLOSE BEHIND. GRACE'S face most likely would be eye-level to her bottom—and Grace would be looking, *looking* at her ass cheeks lifting and shaking as she walked the steep air-stairs in the highest high-heeled shoes she'd ever worn. But doing not too bad, thank you.

But as she mounted the steps and entered the close confines of the small jet's foyer, she came face-to-face with a man in a pilot's uniform. She hitched breath hard and fast enough to make a gulping sound in her throat. Her breath froze in her chest, her step hesitating. Grace's fingertips pressed the small of her back, center, just above the curve of her buttocks, guiding her forward. Fear tightened and trembled her tummy.

While the pilot stood facing her, his head was aside, his eyes averted. Not looking at her. And now her heart swelled with an unexpected feeling of care. She'd been made to display herself, strut naked for anyone who might see—and while Skylar had been trusted to shine a flashlight onto her most private space, these other people were character actors and Grace must have instructed them not to look at the beauty of Grace's young naked subject. That would mean that these people's presence was solely for the theater of Angel's fright. Angel, the young girl afraid of being naked, being forced to confront it, and forced to confront it erect and proud and most of

all show grace despite the fear. What power Grace demonstrated. That Grace could do this for her (not just could, but *would*), was profound, touching . . . and yet simultaneously terrorizing. What couldn't Grace do?

And with all of this revelation before her mind's eye, curtains whisked back, she half-smiled, the left corner of her lips pulling up. She bit her lower lip, then corrected herself. *Stop those nervous tics!* She held her head high, walked proudly past the man—though she might not be able to do it if he were looking—chest thrust out, hard nipples on display, breasts swaying and bouncing with her steps as she turned to the right where the man who wouldn't look at her gestured. She headed through the galley of Grace's private plane, feet cold on a stone tile floor. Past the minimalist kitchen space, she led the way through the plane's belly.

Almost all the surfaces inside the plane were an elegant ivory color, except for curving, swooping trim in wood. Bird's eye wood, maple, bent and curved like it'd been steamed, and it shone with countless coats of lacquer. The wood looked out of place, yet perfectly libertine in the otherwise space age tube with its perfectly round porthole windows. First thought she had: I wish my dad could see this, he'd go bananas.

She clicked along the floor in her high heels, minding her posture, passing an ivory leather divan, some lounge chairs, the space theater-lit low and dramatic by pale halogen hidden under trim, then into a lounging space with another divan across from an LCD TV. On the TV's screen a razor-sharp high-definition view underwater, somewhere turquoise and tropical, schools of brightly colored fish swishing left and right. Then leading still with Grace in tow, walking under the next archway, through a small dim space, just one stride, they entered into what must be their destination: a bedroom.

On her right, a low flat bed sat in a bird's eye trimmed clamshell with a fat mattress dressed with white sheets, turned down under what looked like a cashmere duvet. On the left, a low table dressed with a silver pedestal, and

a silver vase with overflowing flowers. And arranged in neat angles on the table were items she recognized as implements of her sexual release. A riding crop, a leather hank, a paddle, a short beaded rope, and two or three dildos (one in a shocking translucent purple, the shaft scattered with swimming metallic flecks cast in the rubbery plastic.

Grace told her to stop, and she did, still facing toward the tail of the plane. Grace closed the distance behind her, and Angel closed her eyes as her professor's hands went over her bare shoulders and down her arms. She waited. The leather diary was placed on the table, and behind, she could hear Grace removing her topcoat, slinging it on the bed. Her professor said, "Turn and face me."

She pivoted in place, circling to look in her beautiful professor's eyes. Grace studied her, touched both sides of her neck, played with her hair, adjusting it, pulling it forward to hang over her collar. She said, "You did very well."

"I just want to please my Mistress."

Grace smiled, and a flash of regret crossed her face—not wanting her student to see her pleasure right now. Her expression returned to stern. "Very good, indeed. Do you think you've earned your punishment?"

"Punishment?" Her heart sank and she chewed her lip.

Grace softly clapped a hand on the side of her neck and she stopped chewing. Grace said, "There's pleasure in punishment, isn't there?"

She nodded. "Yes."

"I think you did well."

"Well enough?" She *needed* the punishment.

"I think so. Tell me what you learned."

"I did what you asked. I stood up straight, I learned to walk in heels . . ."

"Why would you do that?"

“I don’t know . . . No, I do. It’s my façade. It’s how I present to others. I didn’t show what I felt, I showed poise . . .”

Grace gave a slight nod, and Angel figured she was pretty close to it.

“All right,” Grace said, “I want you on the bed.”

Angel slumped with relief since Grace wasn’t looking her way, enjoying the moment for herself. Perhaps the lessons were over, at least ones that challenged her resolve. All she wanted now were the lessons that taught her the pleasure hidden inside her body. Hidden inside her mind, too. Because this was far more than what touch could do to those sensitive parts of her body, it was how that touch was compounded by the woman’s effect, by the woman’s ability to dominate through gesture and speech and posture and just the look in her eyes. If it were about pleasure, she wouldn’t need Grace. Just leave her be in this room, she was pretty sure she could do what she needed with those items laying on the table. But that wasn’t what she wanted. Not just pleasure. Pleasure *plus* . . .

She turned, put her butt down on the bed, sitting with the high-heeled shoes flat on the floor. “Should I take off my shoes?”

Grace spied over her shoulder, thinking about it. “Yes, I think you should. They’re yours to keep, my dear. But take care of them.”

She eased her feet out of the shoes, saying thank you to Grace, then tucking the shoes under the lip of the bed’s overhang.

Now she was completely naked again. Naked and waiting to see what her Mistress would do . . .

BUT IT WASN’T to be. At least not right way. Grace had removed her suit jacket, showed off her bare arms, but all the while the plane’s jet engines had spooled up into a higher whine. A woman appeared from the dim alcove that separated the bedroom from the TV room and Angel’d drawn her legs up to hide her sex, and covered her breasts with an arm. The

woman, dressed in the uniform of a flight attendant, glanced her way very quickly, showed no reaction before saying to Grace they were ready to take off. Then disappeared.

Grace'd smiled, held out a hand and Angel'd given hers over. Grace led her to the plane's belly, where they were thankfully alone, and sat her naked in one of the ivory lounge chairs where they could buckle their belts.

But while the plane wheeled out of the hangar and onto the tarmac heading to a runway, they held hands, seated side-by-side. Angel'd leaned close to Grace and whispered, "May I check now?" And Grace had asked her what she wanted to check (Grace didn't remember). And she'd told Grace she'd like now to check to see if her professor wore her underthings when she traveled by air. It made Grace smile, and Grace's smile did swoopy things to her heart. The plane worked to the end of the runway, everything black out the plane's round windows, only a deep blue where sky met land and lines of twinkling runway lights. Grace'd unbuttoned her pants and unzipped them, and as the plane accelerated, Grace led Angel's hands inside the pants.

Her heart had raced wildly and it had nothing with the force of acceleration, nor that stomach dropping feeling as the wheels of the plane left the earth. Grace indeed wore no underwear. Angel's hand touched her bare skin, marveled at its silk, at the tautness of the woman's flesh, then a sickly sexual desire upon feeling the scratch of her professor's pubic hair. Her mouth hung agape as her fingers crawled lower and Grace didn't stop her. She felt the yoke of Grace's commissure, felt the furled inner flesh of her vagina, ran two fingers down her center and touched Grace's petals. The feel of her scorching hot sex flesh was incredible and profound and she loved the wetness, loved the soft gummy curls. As the plane rose higher into the night, Grace got wetter under her fingers, and she closed her eyes and wondered at how lucky she was . . .

13

mile high

NOW SHE WAS ON THE CLAMSHELL BED, AND THE FINGERS THAT HAD been inside her professor were curled loosely at her chin. As she breathed, she drew in the deep musky redolence of Grace's pussy, still on her skin. She was naked, on her knees, her cheek pushed into a pillow while Grace sat behind her on the bed.

The plane was in the clouds now and her professor prepared herself to make her student come.

Her stomach trembled with anticipation. But the vulgarity of her body's lurid disposition tightened her muscles. On her knees, face down, bare ass tilted up, her sex and her anus exposed; and sitting right next to that erotic exposition was Grace, fully clothed (though her pants might still be unzipped).

Brought to the bed from the low table were four of the implements of sexual pleasure. Five, if you included the small pump-top bottle of what she figured must be lube. The four items were: the wooden paddle; a foot-and-a-half long strand of beads on a cord; a pair of handcuffs that weren't too severe looking, the cuffs themselves padded; and a dildo, she figured, though it was fat and squat and came to a rounded point. The dildo was short, too, and a leather thong held from its rounded base a feathery pink tail. It was nowhere near as menacing as the purple dildo that was left on

the table, the one with the gold metallic flakes inside. Though the purple one made her curious, she was unsure whether or not she wanted the first thing to fully penetrate her vaginal canal to be a toy. But still, the dildo that Grace had brought to the bed would also be inserted, and though not deep, she was unsure whether she wanted it to be her first non-virgin vaginal experience, either. But she would do—submit to—anything Grace wanted.

For a few minutes now, Grace had been arranging herself and her gear on the bed, moving the items where she would like to have them, making sure they were within her comfortable reach, and Angel could see the professor had crossed her legs, and she watched Grace's bobbing high-heeled shoe. But Grace's face was unseen. That was an intriguing part of the submission. Though she wanted to see her professor's face, there was something exciting about being face-down like this with all her sexual apparatus bared like for a gynecological exam (though she'd never been to a gynecological exam where they had her on her knees like this).

While Grace prepared herself, Angel flexed her thighs, and though her knees were pointed into the mattress, she made futile efforts to pull her knees together, the act tightening her stomach and making the muscles surrounding her vagina flex wonderfully. But the waiting was killing her—

Grace laid a hand on her ass cheek and a flutter of twitches rippled through her body at her professor's touch.

"I'm ready for you now."

"Okay . . ."

"I want you to put your hands down at your knees. Do that for me."

"Okay," she said, gave a last whiff of her professor's heavenly scent on her fingers then put her hands down till her wrists were touching the outsides of her knees.

"Excellent," Grace said, then hooped one of the cuffs on her wrist and locked it. The cable that held the two cuffs tickled at the backs of her calves as she brought the other cuff to the opposite wrist and locked it as well.

Now her hands were on the bed, trapped at her knees, the cable running across the backs of her thighs. The change in her arms' positioning had her face and neck pressing harder into the mattress and pillow.

Now Grace's hands palmed both ass cheeks. The professor would therefore have her face directed at Angel's bared anus and sex. Before she even could enjoy the contemplation of how dirty this was, there was a warm and sticky *wet* feeling in the crack of her ass.

It couldn't be helped: she let out a low quavering moan and drool spilled from the corner of her mouth into the bedding. Her thighs tightened again.

She moaned, "What are you doing?"

Grace didn't answer. And Grace didn't answer—it was clear now—because that was Grace's tongue between her ass cheeks.

Grace's tongue was sliding lower now, going slow and confident, then swooping a circle around her anus. Her toes curled and flexed, and she kicked her feet at the insanely wild thrill. Grace went further, the woman's tongue pulsing against her, flattening, then tightening to a point and prodding at her aperture. She did that for minutes, and Angel's eyes rolled up in her head. Her toes curled in, flexed out, her stomach muscles tightened, loosened, and tightened . . . The sexual spate had returned—she could feel her own slickness. Could feel the greasiness as she flexed her thighs, and her labia moved easily against themselves.

Then Grace was gone, at least her mouth was gone, one hand still on her ass cheek and lightly patting it. Grace said, "I read an essay of yours that said you grew up on a farm."

"Yeah . . ."

Grace patted her ass, then shifted, leaving her alone for a second. The space between her ass cheeks had been moistened by Grace's tongue and now was icy cold in the absence of Grace's warmth."

Grace asked, “What sort of farm?” Then there was a clicking sound, followed a flatulent liquid gush. Grace was pumping lubricant.

“Cuh-corn, m-mostly, and two fields of soybean . . .”

“How large is the farm?”

“A hundred-and-sixty-five a-acres . . .” Her hands twisted and she loved the feel of the cuffs’ restraint.

At Grace’s thigh, Angel could see now her professor’s elegant hands working. They shone with lubricant, and in her grip she held the strand of beads in a dangling loop. She was fondling each bead and coating them with the lubrication. The beads were in acrylic, but looked like jewels—like globes of amber.

“I was born there—not there on the farm, I mean I’ve lived there my whole life . . .”

“Is that so?”

“Yeah, I—”

Grace’s hands returned between her legs. Her touch was now greasy with the lubrication, and she moved knuckles in her ass crack, then swirled the pad of her thumb on Angel’s anus. It curled her toes and arched her feet.

“What are you doing?”

“What does your mother do?”

“She’s a farmer . . . a farmer, too. Homestead, I mean. My dad does the fields. He has help . . . My mom does the . . .”

“It’s a happy home, isn’t it?”

“Uh-huh . . .”

Now there was pressure against her sphincter, and her eyebrows raised as high as they would go. Pressure, and pressure, and *more* pressure and then . . . with a soundless pop, one of those beads had been pushed past the tight ring of her sphincter.

“Happy . . .” she babbled, “Happy home . . . Yeah . . .”

“I thought so. I like to hear that.”

The pressure came again. Grace pushing another one of those beads inside her. It was unbearable, and they were both silent the whole while.

Grace pushed five of those beads into her anus.

“What is this . . . What’s it going to do?”

Grace shifted again, her weight moving around on the mattress, getting Angel jostling. Her colon felt stuffed full with those fat amber marbles. Five of them pushed inside her rectum. The string dangled below, and she could feel the ring on the end tapping the inside of her thighs.

There was a quick whacking sound. The paddle. Grace had tested it’s sting against her own palm.

Grace: “You were never punished?”

“No . . .”

“But you needed it.”

“No, I didn’t.”

“But you need it now.”

“I need it now,” she said. “So bad . . .”

There was a bright snap across her bottom, perfectly level and even across both her ass cheeks. She jumped, and the act tightened her pelvic floor suddenly, and the pressure of those combined balls stuffed in her ass did a funny thing that had her hitching her breath. The pleasure was *unreal*, and yet impossible to pinpoint. Was it her ass? Was it her pussy? Her heart? . . . Or was it all in her head? . . .

Before she had time to even consider, Grace tugged the ring on the end of the string and plucked one of those balls from out of her anus with a stretching billow of pleasure. And that pleasure she felt upon being spanked with the paddle was overwhelmed now by a grander feeling of strange sexual release. She moaned again.

“You like being punished.”

“Yeah . . . yes . . .”

Another bright spank. The paddle snapped across both ass cheeks and she jumped, the jump tightening her pelvic floor and squishing the muscles around her vagina. And then pop. Another bead plucked from her anus . . .

Grace punished her for countless minutes this way. Spanking her, then plucking a bead. When the beads were all free, she pushed them in again and started over. Pluck, pop, spank. Fifteen times the beads were plucked and she could feel the lubrication from her soggy pussy rolling along her stomach and dripping off the lip of her navel. She'd never been wetter. She was wetter now than she was in the limousine.

"Excellent," Grace said. "You're doing very well." She palmed her ass cheeks again, and her thumbs massaged the insides of her thighs, then dove into the creases on either side of her vulva, then came up to tease at her anus again.

"Please touch it . . ."

"Oh no, young Angel—you're not ready for that."

"I *need* it."

"And I *need* your need."

Then Grace's palms were gone again, and Angel trembled in new anticipation.

She knew what was next. It would be the dildo. She needn't worry about losing her virginity to a hunk of plastic: she knew where it would go.

The nose of it pressed against her sphincter now, and she squinted her eyes shut. Her mind focused like a laser on the feel of the bulbous shape spreading her sphincter now. She'd been loosened and warmed up by the beads and the spanking, but still, the girth of the plug was large. She accommodated it.

And just as it was accepted, Grace pulled it in reverse again and teased her with the nose.

"Please, I just need—"

It was inserted again.

And now she could feel the orgasm coming. It was going to happen. Grace hadn't even touched her vagina. This was all anal play, but Grace had plunged from her anus the pleasure Angel desired. No, *needed* . . .

"I'm going . . . I'm going to . . ."

"Yes, you're going to come," Grace said, fucking her ass with the plug.

"I'm going to," she said, "make me, oh make me . . ."

"You're going to come for me."

"Oh, oh, mm, I'm going to come s-so hard . . ."

Grace whispered, "Yes, Angel, yes, you are . . ."

THE SLEEPING CABIN'S lights'd been turned to a dull low purple, and Angel slept now, her head in Grace's lap. She'd intended to work on her research, but once the girl had crawled up the bed and assumed this position, she'd closed and pushed away her laptop, and now stroked the girl's thick blond hair. Her student had fallen asleep, finally relieved of the enormous sexual burden her professor'd loaded on her virgin shoulders. The punishment was a gift of release, and she loved to hear the girl purr softly now in her unburdened slumber. The sharpest pleasure though had been for her, the deliverer of the punishment, and she was grateful that Angel would allow it.

Her phone buzzed in her pants pocket, and she struggled to retrieve it without jostling Angel's head. Angel was undisturbed and Grace responded to Baron's text asking how she was.

Grace: Magnificent. The girl is asleep with her head on my lap after I took half an hour to bring her to an anal orgasm on the plane.

She stroked Angel's hair, plucked on the hem of the cashmere blanket the naked girl curled under, covering her neck.

Baron: poor girl has no idea who she's dealing with.

She smiled, huffed a small laugh.

Grace: No, she doesn't. She is exquisite.

And she truly was. All she and Baron'd ever desired. Too good to be true. Sleeping now on her side, softly breathing, the blanket rising and falling, the student and the professor sharing in post-orgasmic ataraxy. They'd experienced their first real scenario together. It was incredible. And it was only a taste of what would come.

Baron: I wish I was home

She texted her husband back, one thumb typing, her other hand on Angel's shoulder.

Grace: Will you be home on time tomorrow?

Baron: Nothing will stop me

She chuckled again, knowing he meant it—*nothing* would stop him. She ached to be with him. Ached to be with him and Angel together, all three of them. The plane began to descend, she could sense the change of altitude in her stomach.

Grace: I hate to wake her, but we're descending. She sleeps so beautifully.

Baron: You're smitten

Always chastising her, reminding her to guard her emotions. Her of all people. But her shoulders sagged, and the heavy feeling in her stomach was now kept company with a heaviness in her heart. A vague, nameless dread; always the worry of what bad things the next day may bring. She admitted to the love of her life her own weakness.

Grace: I'm smitten

It took a moment for Baron to respond, probably reeling at his steely wife's unexpected admission.

Baron: Be careful

Grace: I know what I'm doing

Baron changed the subject.

Baron: I wish it were tomorrow night right now and I had you in my arms

Grace: I can't wait either, love. I wish we could skip the gala and just stay in our quarters.

She waited for his response and he took quite some time crafting what he wanted to say, his dancing dots disappearing, reappearing . . . but when his message came through it wasn't the dirty talk she'd expected.

Baron: My cousin tells me Storm will be at the gala

She groaned quietly and let her head fall back against the padded wall of the sleeping shell, then she shook her head and rolled her eyes up to the dark ceiling.

She texted.

Grace: I look forward to seeing him

Baron: I'm sure you do

Now she chuckled again, smiling at her husband's message. She bid him farewell, telling him of how much she missed him and loved him, and he said so as well, and they promised to talk tomorrow before signing off.

She took a moment to steady herself, staring at the dim line of purple light hidden behind the sleeping cabin's trim, then tucked her phone back in her pocket. The plane's descent was more pronounced now, and she gently shook Angel's shoulder, watching the way the dim purple painted light on the curves of her student's beautiful face. "Angel, wake," she whispered, "we're descending . . ."

14

white caps

THEY DROVE SOUTH FROM THE AIRPORT IN PROVIDENCE FOR A HALF hour, Skylar at the wheel again, the car they were in now a black Bentley with white leather interior and wood trim. It made her wonder if that was Grace's favorite combination, considering the interior of the private jet.

Before disembarking the jet, Grace'd provided her with a new outfit delivered to the sleeping cabin by the female flight attendant, and she'd adorned her naked body while her professor'd watched. Chanel again, all the items: an embroidered silk tulle blouse in see-through black that looked like pastel flower petals clung to it—Grace provided no undergarments, so she was braless, her breasts and nipples showing; a very high-waisted white cotton skirt that ended mid-thigh; a skinny belt adorned with crystals in pearl, in pink, and in orange; black tights; Mary Janes in black with a pointed toe and a tiny ankle strap. Thankfully, she'd also been returned Grace's wool coat to keep warm (and to hide her visible breasts).

Grace'd asked if Angel'd mind if she took the opportunity to work on her book during the car ride, and Angel would never object, though she would've preferred to sit with her professor and talk. She did ask what the book was about, but Grace said she had to decline to discuss due to contracts with her publisher.

Her anus buzzed, sitting in the plush luxury cabin of the Bentley watching out the windows as Providence became Kingstown. Her beautiful professor had made her orgasm so hard from punishing her anus she'd rendered her babbling and drooling on the bedding like a fool. She wondered if she should be embarrassed. One thing was for sure: her pussy still ached to be touched, stroked, petted . . . and for the first time, she absolutely felt a prominent demand to have something *inside* it. That would be Baron's doing, not Grace's. She hardly knew Baron. What would it be like?

They crossed two long bridges, passing over the wintry hump of Conanicut Island in between, the second bridge delivering them into the City of Newport. She kept quiet most of the trip, but if she would remark on something she saw out the window that was interesting (she'd never been this far east before), Grace would pause a moment from writing in her laptop to offer some insight. During the drive she worried maybe somehow—she honestly couldn't figure the *how*—she'd displeased Mistress, and yearned to simply ask, but feared the query itself would be displeasing. So she said nothing.

But at last, passing through Newport's mix of Colonial and modern, Grace began to put away her things, saying they were almost to the house.

Angel put on her best posture and smile. "How long have you lived there?"

"We don't. It's one of Baron's family's homes. His brother, Storm, stays there mostly—when he's in the U.S.—we use it occasionally when we're north of Manhattan. But Manhattan is our real home."

"Doesn't Baron work in Rhode Island?" She was thinking of his possible connection to a company called Oxbow in Providence. When Grace didn't answer immediately, her eyes raised to her professor's. Saw puzzlement in her eyes. Right—how would *she* know where Baron worked

if Grace had never told her? She was a snoop, that's how. Instantly, her cheeks blazed and she looked away.

Grace said, "Baron has an office in Providence. And one in Manhattan. And he's not often at either."

"Oh, okay," Angel whispered, bottomlessly ashamed.

Outside, the Bentley had wound itself south of the city and now they were moving slower between narrow streets ridged with hedges—behind the hedges she could see grand homes.

The Bentley slowed to a crawl, and she leaned aside to look out toward the front of the vehicle. Skylar was segmented from their cabin by a smoky glass divider—the Bentley far more private than Grace's Vermont vehicles. The road was separated from a property by a high stone wall; out front of the wall stood a long hedge barrier of blue-green buxus kept neatly trimmed in an artful undulating line. The Bentley's headlights shone on a set of wrought iron gates swinging inward to allow their passage. Now she craned further to see where the drive would lead, but nothing was revealed except a winding wooded trail. It switchbacked, and out the side window she would catch glimpses of a big body of black water. Soon they were in the open and she could see the home. A mansion. She couldn't help an awed *whoah* from slipping past her lips, then regretted the bumpkinish sound.

Grace sidled closer, saying, "White Caps. That's the mansion's name. Built by the Van Heusen family in 1850. It's been in Baron's family forever."

"Did he grow up here?"

"He and his brothers spent a lot of time here, yes."

"It's beautiful." And it was. She'd never seen a place like it in real life. Only movies. A grand three-story mansion by the ocean that looked like a Renaissance palace with its limestone walls, arched windows, the entrance with a huge stone pediment, sculptures of women above (Roman goddesses probably). Amber lights shone from the ample gardens buttressing the

footing, and it glowed against the starry nighttime sky. When she turned to regard Grace, she saw out the other window the silvery arrows of wave crests on the black ocean.

“What’s that water—the ocean?”

“Yes. Sheep Point Cove to be specific.”

The Bentley circled a winter garden and pulled underneath a carport out front of the mansion’s wide stone steps leading up to huge brass doors. An Asian man in a white smock and black pants awaited them, opening the car door before Skylar had even exited the vehicle. Grace gestured for her to go ahead, and she took the man’s offered hand. He helped her out of the car. She stood waiting for Grace to join her, the cold seeping up the skirt and under the jacket, tightening her nipples. She cozied herself in Grace’s coat. Grace instructed Skylar and the other man to bring their things into the house, then took Angel’s arm and led her side-by-side up the steps and through the double doors into the mansion’s foyer.

If Grace had been intimidating before, now seeing the vast wealth of her and Baron’s family on display had her knees literally shaking. A tremble sizzled in her lower back, the small muscles twitching. It ignited a residual phantom feeling of Grace’s play with her anus, and now she felt simultaneously overwhelmed by fortune-awe and sexual subjugation.

“It’s incredible,” she whispered. The foyer was high and immense, with tall archways heading off to various regions of the enormous home; a grand marble staircase (complete with a ruby red carpet runner) led to the second floor where balconies opened behind wrought iron railings. Mansion staff moved around, seen in the distance passing by doorways, averting their eyes.

Grace stopped her, put her hands on her shoulders, both of them in the center of an Oriental rug over the marble floor. High above, a painting of another Roman goddess peered down from the palatial ceiling. “Can I get you dinner—are you hungry at all?”

She shook her head. “I ate before the car picked me up.”

“At the diner?”

“Yeah.”

Grace wasn’t pleased. “Tomorrow we’ll get you some better food.”

“Tomorrow?” It sounded as though the evening was over—but they’d only arrived.

“We have a very busy day tomorrow, Angel.”

It had to be asked: “Did I displease you, Mistress?”

Grace’s troubled expression softened. And it wasn’t until she witnessed the change that she realized her professor had been troubled to begin with. That’s what it was—not displeasure. Their eyes met and held, then Grace lowered to kiss her with those sticky-soft lips. She closed her eyes as Grace cupped her neck and thumbed her jawline.

“You please me greatly,” she said, looking deep in her eyes, and relieving her of the worry. Though some stayed, the fear of having disappointed her professor replaced with concern for what could trouble a woman like Grace Chen. “Now let me show you your bedroom . . .”

15

rising steam

THE BEDROOM REMINDED HER OF WEDDING CAKES. WALLS IN PRETTY pink wallpaper printed with raised velvet paisley in the same shade; trim all in white—swooping, curling, scrollwork . . . the ceiling all in white, too, with more of the same scrolling decoration. It looked like the room of a pre-pubescent Victorian princess. All the furniture was elaborate and decorative, all in white as well, upholstery in the same pale rose petal pink. The room was on the ground floor, the windows almost ten feet tall, and from where they were at the back of the mansion she thought the view might look out at the ocean.

Grace walked her into the room, smiling affectionately. They congregated near the center of the vast room, Grace gesturing toward the bed—another oversized piece of furniture in white, set up high on a pedestal she'd have to mount using the three steps on either side of the bed. Folded in neat bundles on the bed were items of clothing, and Grace said, “I didn’t know how you like to sleep, so I had them get you pajamas, a nightdress, some sweats. Whatever you like. You may sleep naked if that’s what you prefer.”

The mansion was a little chilly, and she didn’t sleep naked, so she stepped up onto the pedestal and fingered through the arranged items. The sweats were emblazoned with the Morrison College logo (it was touching to

think Grace might consider MCV clothing could cushion any homesickness she might feel).

“Thank you,” she said. Then: “This is all so overwhelming,” rolling her eyes around the extravagant and luxurious room Grace’d put her up in.

Grace joined her on the bed pedestal, and though Angel hoped she’d touch her, her professor kept her hands at her sides for the moment. “You’ll become accustomed.”

“I doubt it,” she said, and chuckled awkwardly.

Grace said, “I did.”

“Okay,” she agreed softly.

“Tomorrow we’ll get you fitted for a gala dress. How does that sound?”

“Expensive.”

At last Grace touched her. Cupped a hand on her cheek, then caressed her neck. “Money’s never an obstacle for my pleasure.”

Foreboding and unexpected words from her professor. Not knowing how to respond, she relied on whispering okay again. Grace smiled.

“I’m worn from travel, so I’d like to retire now, and you as well. We’ll start early. How does that sound?”

“It’s good.”

“Before you change, Angel, I’d like you to regard yourself in the mirror. There’s a standup in the closet. Study yourself. See if you’ve changed. Tell me in the morning.”

With that, her professor’s warm hand left her skin, and she stepped down to the bedroom floor, headed for the door. Angel called out “Good night,” to her, and Grace waved over a shoulder before leaving and closing the tall double doors (also in white) behind her. Leaving her alone.

It was unfortunate and strange and left her with an empty feeling. She hadn’t thought clearly on what would happen once they arrived at Grace’s house, but the loneliness now told her she’d anticipated sleeping in the same bed with her professor. That’s what she would have chosen if offered

a choice. The two women cuddled together under sheets, feeling the warmth and silk of each other's skin . . .

With an MCV sweatshirt and sweatpants under her arm, she trotted off the pedestal and crossed toward what she thought might be the walk in closet. It was the bathroom. She tried another tall door and found the closet, flicked on the light, set the bundled sweats down on an upholstered chair before approaching the mirror set in its white frame and stand.

She saw herself in the reflection. Did she look different? She wasn't sure. She'd seen the coat before, so she removed it. Stood now before the mirror wearing the expensive clothes. Of course she looked different. What did Grace mean? Her hair wasn't exactly styled very nice, a messy strawberry blond shag. Her posture was soggy—so she fixed it. Sucked in her stomach, straightened her back and thrust her chest out. Yeah, that was different. She could see her nipples right through the fabric. But she guessed she could infer Grace's meaning. She didn't look like a college student. She looked like a woman. Or at least a young adult. Youth was seeping out of her, leaving her with . . . oh, shit—was it grace? Now she laughed and covered her mouth. Sure, one private jet plane ride, a flashlight on your crotch, a mile-high anal orgasm, some Chanel clothes . . . next thing you know, you're a full blown debutante. But maybe *some* progress had been made . . . she'd taken a few steps from her hayseed roots.

She stood a quiet moment longer just looking at her reflection, then abandoned the sweats on the chair and left the closet, heading for the bed, coat over her shoulder. The weight of her phone in its pocket clunked on her back, and she retrieved it, thinking to check messages before she slept.

Shit. Five of them tonight from Brian. Add those to the twelve in the last few days.

A woman would deal with this already. A woman like the woman Grace'd hoped Angel would see in the mirror would definitely have dealt with this. Grace would have, for sure . . .

Ahead of her she could see in the gap of the ceiling-high pink draperies what she'd thought was a window wasn't a window at all. It was a door. She paused at the glass, peering outside and seeing a terrace, stone steps leading aside into a dark garden. The property was lit and inviting and she thought she'd rather be outside making this call over inviting her boyfriend—ex-boyfriend—into this palatial bedroom, even just telephonically.

She donned Grace's coat, tested the lever, worried about a sudden hooting from some unseen alarm, but when none came, stepped outside into the cold. Collar turned up, she walked the terrace and marveled at the intimate space of paths and gardens behind the mansion. The terrace was elevated by a half dozen feet and she could see out over the tops of the shrubbery, wondering how beautiful it must all be in spring and summer when these gardens would likely teem with flowers. And indeed, extending out beyond the gardens and a buffer of lawn, was the ocean, rushing and roaring, souging a damp chill against her cheeks. And there was no beach, no strip of sand lit silver by the moon. In fact, the lawn appeared to end in a drop off, a cliffside that fell toward the water.

A walk in the gardens might be calming, she figured, while placating the boy at home who was no longer her boyfriend (no matter what he might say), and she skipped down the steps in her Mary Janes, swiping light to her phone, dialing Brian all the way back in Hager Hill, Illinois.

Brian answered the phone saying, "Where the hell have you been? . . ."

JUST LIKE THAT, she was back on her heels—not the fine heels of her Mary Janes, more like the cheap squeaking sneakers she wore in the halls of Hager Hill High. "I'm here now."

"You haven't called me in a week."

"I know—I told you how busy I—"

"So busy you can't fire off a text?"

“It’s not as simple as—”

“You’re on your phone *all* the time—you can’t just type out with your thumbs and let me know you got my messages?”

“I had to think of something to say . . .”

“Just let me know you’re alive, for fuck sake, Angel.”

“You know I’m alive.”

“I’d like to hear from you. Why can’t you just send me a message?”

“I told you, I had to spend time to think about what I wanted to say . . .”

“Why?”

The real answer was: *Because I broke it off with you . . . You don’t believe that I did, but I did . . .* Instead, she said, “Your gift . . .”

“You should have told me you got it.”

“I’m sorry . . .”

“Why didn’t you tell me? You know what I’m thinking?—all this time here at home, you’re out there and you won’t even get back to me after I send you a—”

“I know, I know. I said I’m sorry. I’m under a lot of pressure . . .”

“I get that, Angel. I’m not trying to put more pressure on you . . .”

Yeah, right.

“. . . but it’s been, like two weeks. I don’t hear from you for two weeks? After I send you . . .”

“It was beautiful,” she said. And it was. Touching, too. But didn’t he understand it was unwelcome?

“Are you wearing it?”

“Yeah . . .” *She wasn’t.*

“Where are you?”

“At the dorm.”

“I don’t know if you’re lying or not.”

“Why would I lie?”

“You tell me. You’re the one who turned off their Find My Phone.”

“Yeah, I turned it off. I’m not in Hager Hill anymore.” (And I’m not your property) “What does it matter? I’m always on campus. Where do you think I go? Sometimes I go into the village to do my laundry, but . . .”

She’d been walking the path, gardens on one side, falling away to the lawn, hedgerows zigzagging, and stone benches forming seating areas. On the left-hand side the path stayed close to the mansion. Ahead was a glass-walled conservatory attached to the rear of the mansion, the kind of place you would assume was a greenhouse, someplace where the wealthy Van Heusen women grew herbs and rare flowers. It was dimly lit from inside, but she could see nothing beyond its glass walls. In her ear, Brian breathed. And having known him so long, even though no words were spoken, she could hear the anger in his breath. The slightest detection of a growl in the back of his throat as he deeply inhaled then exhaled.

She continued: “I don’t know what you want me to say.”

“Are you coming home at Thanksgiving?”

“Yeah . . . or, I don’t know,” she said shrugging, looking up at the starlit sky. “Probably . . .”

“You don’t even sound like you want to.”

“Of course I want to, Brian. Do you know how much I miss home? How much I miss my family? You say you’re not trying to put pressure on me, but . . .”

“I’m not. Don’t put this on me. I’m not trying to put pressure on you . . . I only do *nice* things. You’re the one who’s always acting like such a bitch . . .”

“I’m not. Don’t call me that.”

The light from the conservatory spilled on her shoes now, and as she drew nearer the side of the conservatory she saw that while it may at one time have held racks and tables of orchids, and roses, strange flowers from Japan, spices from India, it was all gone, emptied now, and in its place a

beautiful marble indoor pool. The lights were low, the cavernous room empty, steam emanating from the water's surface.

"I just can't wait to see you, is that a crime?"

"It's not a crime." She palmed her forehead, massaged her tightening brow. "I guess . . . Yeah, you know, I'll see you when I come home."

"So you're telling me you're coming home for Thanksgiving?"

She rolled her eyes, felt her weight sag on her fine shoes, huddled herself tighter in Grace's coat. "Yes. I'm coming home for Thanksgiving."

"You want to Face Time?"

"I look like a mess right now."

"You know I don't care."

"I'd rather not."

She could sense he'd chilled. Then that angry breathing again. He said, "*Are you in the dorm—or are you lying?*"

"Where else would I be?"

Now from within the conservatory, light blossomed in a rectangular slash, a door on the far end opening. A figure emerged in the long alcove, strolled now into the pale light spilling around the stone pool deck. It was Grace in a shimmering robe. The first thing she noticed was Grace's bare feet. *Why would she be thrilled by such a sight?*

"If you're fucking somebody, I swear to God I'm going to fucking lose my mind."

She whined: "Why would you even you *say* that?"

"You know how fucking hard it is, you away at college and I'm still here?"

"Brian, I told you . . ."

"What?—don't say it."

I'm not even going with you, I broke up with you . . .

"Brian, I told you why I want things the way I want them. I can't have them any other way. It's so hard for me out here. You act like it's hard for

you there, but you're home. I say it to you all the time, it's like you don't listen. The pressure here is crazy. I feel like I'm going to get kicked out, like they'll realize I'm not worthy . . ."

"They'd be crazy to kick you out. You're so fucking smart."

"It takes more than that. Everybody here's smart," she murmured.

Then beyond the glass, Grace strode poolside to a wrought iron table, a glass of wine in one hand, a slim laptop under her other arm. But bundled with the laptop something spiked her heart and widened her eyes. Her leather bound diary. The confessions she'd made. The desires she'd committed onto paper.

"I gotta go."

"What—your boyfriend's calling?"

"What do you mean?"

"The guy you're seeing there."

She was indignant. "Do you have any idea how little time I have?"

"Don't be so rude to me . . ."

"I'm not being rude. You're acting like college is some party."

"You know it is."

"You know *I'm* not like that," she said, watching Grace now as she set the wineglass, laptop, and diary on the tabletop. Her professor was everything she wanted to be. Every move Grace made she coveted. The way her silky red and gold robe hung from her lithe frame, the movements of her slender arms and legs. Grace turned, facing the pool—facing Angel—untied the knot in the robe's black tasseled belt, the robe falling open . . . Angel was shown a naked stripe of Grace's center—beautiful skin from neck to toes, her navel, the triangle of black fur between her thighs (her fingers tingled at the sight of her pussy, knowing what it was to touch her there), then Grace stepped forward, pushing back her shoulders and letting the silk slide off her bare body, tossing the weightless fabric, slinging it over a spindly iron chair.

She strode naked to the edge of the pool, muscles working under her skin, swaying her hips, breasts jostling with her light steps—smallish teacup breasts, tawny skin, chocolatey brown nipples, puffed as though alerted but not yet aroused.

The sight of her, so amazing, so beautiful, so *revealed*, made her guts constrict and squirm. A desire. A longing to touch the woman finally, to embrace her, to feel their naked bodies intertwined. Without thinking, she'd raised her hand to her mouth and nose, pressed a knuckle to her lips and suckled. The hand she'd used to explore her professor's vagina. The hand that had touched the woman's slick petals, and had worn her scent. In fact, she could still detect a ghostly trace of her wonderful sexual musk on her own skin.

Angel went lightheaded, dipping at the knees, eyes wide as saucers, holding her breath; her heart pounded in her eardrums.

"I said I gotta go . . ."

"Yeah, go. If you cheat on me, I swear to God . . ."

"I'm not cheating on you," she said in a robotic monotone, eyes on her professor.

"Just go. Why don't you send me a picture of the bracelet? I mean, it'd be a polite thing to do . . ."

"Brian, I really have to go . . ."

"Just text me every once in a while. Just promise me you'll do that."

"Yeah . . . okay . . ." She watched Grace's naked flesh, heart racing from fear she'd be discovered spying. "I love you," she said, thumbing the red circle to end the call. It'd be minutes later she realized she'd told Brian she loved him. Two weeks before she'd regret it.

Now, all she concentrated on was the naked form of Grace Chen, hair undone and hanging over her shoulders, down to her waist. Her pretty toes curled the pool's rounded marble coping edge.

Angel stepped back out of the light spilling from the conservatory, moving till it slipped off the points of the shoes Grace gave her. Grace dove into the steaming water, disappearing under the surface, coming up again three quarters down the pool's length, wet shining hair plastered to her cheeks. She breaststroked. Angel watched her professor swim laps, even just the movements of her arms on the water's surface a nimble ballet.

She chewed her lips while she watched, wanting to see her naked again, waiting . . . the whole while her hips slowly shimmied, thighs pressed together, the buzzing of her abused anus shining brighter as she watched the woman who'd done something incredible to her tonight.

Lap after lap, Grace swam, and Angel stayed and watched in the cold while the ocean roared behind her.

At long last her professor ceased, folding arms over the pool edge and breathing heavily, bobbing and kicking while her heart rate subsided. She gathered her long hair, squeezed out the water, pushed it off her back to hang in a wet bundle at her chest. Hands on the marble coping, she hoisted her long body out of the water and hiked a leg onto the deck, crouched, then rose to stand.

A lightning strike sizzled through her seeing Grace's naked back. Though she should never have been spying on her Mistress in the first place, what she saw now was something obviously so personal and private, she felt so deeply ashamed she'd spied at all. Scars. Pain and hurt lined on her professor's back.

The enormity of the marks lacing Grace's skin saddened her and frightened her all at once. Grace's slender back was a lacework of slash scars. Long lines of scar tissue, short lines too, all criss-crossing from shoulders to waist. Angel stepped further back from the light, trembling, features scrunching like she would cry, wounded by the pain she saw painted on her professor.

Grace strode to the table, still hair-squeezing, water running off her beautiful body. She sat in the chair, crossed her long legs and sipped the wine.

While Grace keyed open the leather bound diary and began reading her virgin student's most secret confessions, Angel wiped tears from her lower lids, stepped further into the shadow, heading back to her room.

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